Syntactic ergativity without inversion in Kalaallisut

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Abstract

Kalaallisut (Inuit; Greenland) is a well-known example of a syntactically ergative language, serving as the primary example of that language type in Bittner and Hale (1996a). In relative clauses, ergatives cannot be relativized; there is an ergative extraction constraint (EEC). From Bittner and Hale (1996a) onward, analyses of the EEC standardly appeal to inversion: the absolutive object must obtain an A-position higher than the ergative subject as a matter of basic clause structure, but object movement over the subject blocks further A' movement by the subject. In this paper we re-evaluate this analysis for Kalaallisut. Considering patterns of word order, Condition C, hyperraising, scope, and affix order, we conclude that objects do *not* obligatorily move over subjects in the clause structure of this language. Inversion is not the correct approach to the EEC in Kalaallisut. Our results provide new support for non-inversion based analyses of the EEC such as those grounded in case sensitivity or antilocality, as well as for Ershova's (2019, 2025) contention that the EEC and inversion must be typologically separated from one another.

1 Introduction

An important manifestation of syntactic ergativity cross-linguistically is the impossibility of extracting a transitive subject. Aissen 2017 calls this the *Ergative Extraction Constraint* (EEC). The EEC famously holds in participial relative clauses in Kalaallisut (Inuit, Greenland; a.k.a. 'West Greenlandic'), as discussed by Bittner and Hale (1996a). Baseline transitive and intransitive clauses in Kalaallisut are shown in (1); note that the transitive subject bears ergative case suffix *-p*. The examples in (2) show the EEC: intransitive subjects can be relativized, as can transitive objects, but attempted relativization of the transitive subject results in ungrammaticality.[1]

(1) a. Qimmeq sinip-poq.
dog.ABS sleep-3SG.IND
The dog is sleeping.

[1] The following abbreviations are used in glosses: ABS = absolutive, ACC = accusative, ALL = allative case, AP = antipassive, APPL = applicative, CAU = causative mood, CON = conditional mood, CONJ = conjunction, CONT = contemporative mood, DEM = demonstrative, ERG = ergative, F, FOC = focus, FUT = future, GEN = genitive, HAB = habitual, IND = indicative mood, INST = instrumental, INT = interrogative mood, IP = intransitive participle, NEG = negation, NOMZ = nominalizer, PART = participial mood, PFV = perfective, PL = plural, PRF = perfect, SG = singular, TVZ = transitivizer. 1SG>3SG.IND means first person singular subject acting on third person singular object in indicative mood. 1SG>3SG.ERG means first person singular possessor with a third person singular possessum in an ergative possessive DP.

b. Qimmi-p nukappiaraq kii-vaa.
dog-ERG boy.ABS bite-3SG>3SG.IND
The dog bit the boy.

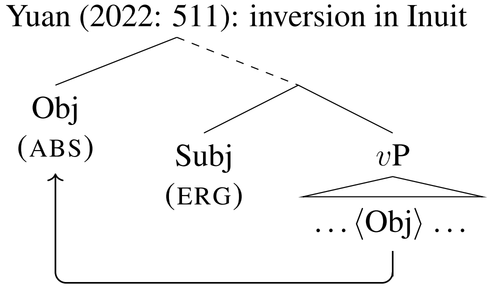
(2) a. Qimmeq [$_{\text{RC}}$ ___$_{\text{ABS}}$ sinit-toq] peqqi-nngi-laq.
dog.ABS [sleep-3SG.PART] be.well-NEG-3SG.IND
The dog that is sleeping is not well.

b. Nupappiaraq [$_{\text{RC}}$ qimmi-p ___$_{\text{ABS}}$ kii-gaa] tammar-poq.
boy.ABS [dog-ERG bite-3SG>3SG.PART] disappear-3SG.IND
The boy that the dog bit disappeared.

c. * Qimmeq [$_{\text{RC}}$ ___$_{\text{ERG}}$ nukappiaraq kii-gaa] tammar-poq.
dog.ABS [boy.ABS bite-3SG>3SG.PART] disappear-3SG.IND
Intended: The dog that bit the boy disappeared.

Research both specific to Inuit languages (including Kalaallisut) and on other languages showing the EEC has converged on a standard analysis of this restriction, which involves syntactic inversion of the absolutive object over the ergative subject. (For inversion analyses of Inuit, see Bittner 1988, 1994a, Murasugi 1992, 1997, Bittner and Hale 1996a,b, Manga 1996, Wharram 2003, Yuan 2018, 2021, 2022; for other languages showing the EEC, notably those in the Mayan and Austronesian language families, see Aldridge 2004 *et seq*, Coon et al. 2015, 2021, Assmann et al. 2015, Tollan and Clemens 2022, Royer 2022, Brodkin and Royer 2024, among others.) This inversion is schematized in (3), following Yuan (2022). The core idea is that languages showing the EEC are those where the object A-moves above the ergative subject in transitive clauses as a matter of basic clause structure.[2] In the terminology popularized by Coon et al. (2015), ergative languages with clause structure of this type are "high absolutive" (high-ABS) languages.

(3) Yuan (2022: 511): inversion in Inuit

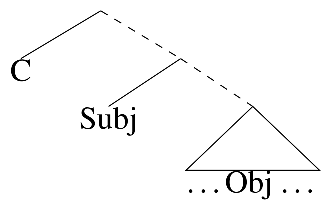


Authors adopting this type of account of the EEC have offered a range of explanations for why and how movement of the object should block subject extraction. Some, for instance, posit that the high object position is one that the subject would need to move through or to in order to extract; the presence of the object there blocks extraction (Bittner and Hale 1996a,b, Coon et al. 2015, Assmann et al. 2015). Others appeal to a grammatical constraint on crossing dependencies (Campana 1992, Tollan and Clemens 2022). Still others appeal to an intervention effect: Ā-movement is driven by a probe on C, which is configured to stop when it encounters any DP. It finds the object first, and therefore stops probing before encountering the subject (Aldridge 2004, Coon et al.

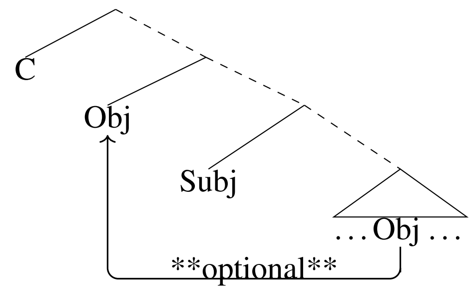
[2]While Bittner and Hale (1996a,b) identify the relevant high object position as an "Ā-position", we note that their usage of this term does not match contemporary usage (and is more akin to what in current terms would be termed an "athematic position").

2021). While these theories diverge in why and how they take structures like (3) to block extraction of the ergative subject, they converge on the idea that a fundamental ingredient to the EEC is *obligatory* object A-movement over the subject *as a matter of basic clause structure*. A language where the subject always occupies the highest A-position in the basic clausal structure, as in (4), or even one where the object may A-move past the subject but only optionally, as in (5), is not expected to show the EEC.

(4) Clausal structure without inversion



(5) Clausal structure with optional inversion



Among morphologically ergative languages, a clause structure such as (4) has been defended for Tsez (Polinsky and Potsdam 2001) and Ch'ol (Coon et al. 2015), among others. The theories discussed above all predict languages of this type to permit subject extraction, because the object does not occupy the problematic high position. On a crossing paths theory, subject movement should be possible because the path of the subject to C does not cross over an object-movement path. On an intervention theory, the object is not closer to the C probe than the subject is, and so once again, subject movement should be permitted.

Much the same goes for a clause structure such as (5), where the object *can* A-move over the subject but does not *need* to—a proposal which has been defended for morphologically ergative languages such as Hindi (Mahajan 1990), Warlpiri (Legate 2002), and Nez Perce (Deal 2017a). Languages of this type are sometimes described as showing "A-scrambling." In a language with A-scrambling, there are two possible structures for a clause, one with object A-movement and one without. In Hindi, for instance, basic SOV order reflects the structure with no A-scrambling; A-scrambling produces OSV order as in (6b).[3]

(6) Hindi (Bhatt 2003)

a. Ram-ne roṭii khaa-i
Ram-ERG bread.F eat.PFV.F
Ram ate bread.

b. Roṭii$_i$ Ram-ne __$_i$ khaa-i
bread.F Ram-ERG eat.PFV.F
Ram ate bread.

In a language allowing optional A-movement of the object over the subject, in order to extract the subject, we need only make sure we begin with a basic clause in which the object movement option was not taken—(6a), not (6b). This means starting with a clause structure as in (4), in which

[3]On word order and scrambling in Hindi, see Mahajan (1990), Bhatt (2016), Keine (2020), among others.

subject extraction is freely available, as noted just above. According to this standard picture on EEC effects, then, the EEC is expected only in languages that not just *permit* object A-movement over the subject, but in fact *require* it. If a clause structure is available in which the object does not A-move past the subject, that structure is expected to allow for transitive subjects to extract.

The Kalaallisut language has historically been central to this type of analysis, owing to the seminal work of Bittner (1988, 1994a) and especially Bittner and Hale (1996a). In the early 1990s, while a distinction between 'morphologically ergative' and 'syntactically ergative' languages had been drawn in the literature for some time already (Dixon 1979, Plank 1979), very few languages had been convincingly classified as syntactically ergative—essentially just Dyirbal.[4] By demonstrating that syntactic ergativity was also found in Kalaallisut, and furthermore that relativization of ergative subjects was a prime place to look for syntactic ergativity, Bittner and Hale (1996a) set the stage for the modern era in syntactic ergativity research. In the wake of their work, the EEC has come to function as the standard manifestation of syntactic ergativity.[5] Inversion analyses of the general type Bittner and Hale promoted have proliferated. And of course Kalaallisut itself has become a standardly cited example of a syntactically ergative language to which the inversion analysis as in (3) is applicable.

Against this backdrop, in this paper we re-evaluate the case for inversion as an explanation for the EEC in Kalaallisut. We focus on the basic clause structure of the language: does Kalaallisut indeed require objects to move over subjects, obligatorily, as a matter of basic clause structure? We present three arguments that the best answer is *no*. In each case, the form of our argument is the same: an analysis without inversion permits a treatment of the Kalaallisut data that is simpler and more in line with general grammatical principles. The first argument comes from basic word order. On an inversion account, we expect the high position of the object to be reflected in basic word order, if indeed this movement is an obligatory part of clause structure and is leftward. Contrary to this prediction, the basic word order of Kalaallisut is SOV. The second argument comes from Condition C effects. A-movement is generally taken to both feed Condition C (i.e., A-movement creates structures in which Condition C effects apply) and bleed it (i.e., A-movement removes Condition C effects that hold in the pre-movement structure). We expect, therefore, that movement of the object over the subject will feed and bleed Condition C—an argument shown to be correct for other languages with an EEC by Paul (2002) and Brodkin and Royer (2024). Our findings are notably different from Paul's and Brodkin and Royer's, however: we find no indication of inversion feeding or bleeding Condition C in Kalaallisut. The simplest analysis of the word order and Condition C data is that the language does not have obligatory inversion as in (3).

Our third argument against obligatory inversion comes from hyperraising, i.e. A-movement across finite clause boundaries. This argument is notable in that it suggests that, while Kalaallisut lacks obligatory inversion, it does allow *optional* inversion, a.k.a. A-scrambling, of the type also seen in Hindi. As A-movement, we expect hyperraising to apply only to the highest DP in an A-position (minimality). Transitive subjects can hyperraise, as we would expect if Kalaallisut totally lacked inversion—i.e., given a clausal structure like (4). Transitive objects can also hyperraise, however, providing evidence for an optional inversion structure (A-scrambling) as in (5). We

[4]Bok-Bennema (1991: 37) writes, for instance, that "apart from Dyirbal, all ergative languages are of the morphological type"; Murasugi (1992: 96) writes "it is generally assumed that syntactically ergative languages are rare, perhaps limited to a few languages such as Dyirbal."

[5]Ershova (2025) describes the current state of the literature in even stronger terms: "syntactic ergativity has largely come to be *equated* with the constraint on ergative displacement" (emphasis added).

conclude overall that Kalaallisut objects are not required to move above subjects, but they may optionally scramble to this type of position. That is to say, the clausal structure of this language is akin to that of Hindi, Warlpiri, or Nez Perce, all of which lack an EEC. (In other terms, these languages are purely "morphologically ergative", not "syntactically ergative".) We conclude that the proper analysis of the EEC in Kalaallisut cannot be in terms of obligatory inversion in clausal structure.

The paper is organized as follows. In the next three sections we present our central arguments against obligatory inversion in basic clause structure, based on patterns of word order (§2), Condition C (§3), and hyperraising (§4). In section 5 we turn to previous arguments *for* inversion in Kalaallisut, based on scope and affix order, and show that these fail to provide compelling evidence of inversion in light of modern theories of scope-taking and agreement. Having argued against the inversion structure, in section 6 we discuss alternative accounts of the EEC that do not require inversion, based on case sensitivity (Otsuka 2006, 2010, Legate 2008a, Deal 2016, 2017b, Drummond 2023) and antilocality (Erlewine 2016, Liu 2025). We also consider the typological picture emerging from this work. In particular, putting our conclusions together with those of Ershova (2019, 2025), we argue that the EEC and inversion are entirely independent of each other. Some languages with obligatory inversion show the EEC; others do not (Ershova 2019, 2025). Some languages *without* obligatory inversion show it, as we argue for Kalaallisut here; others certainly do not. Any account of the EEC which aspires to full crosslinguistic coverage must therefore look to factors other than an inversion-based clause structure as predictors of the ban on extracting ergatives.

As contextualization for the following sections, we note that Kalaallisut is a polysynthetic language with quite free *pro*-drop. Subjects and objects both show ϕ-agreement with the verb, typically forming a portmanteau inflection along with mood. This portmanteau of subject agreement, object agreement, and mood occurs on the right edge of the verb word. (We discuss the question of whether the agreement suffix is in fact morphologically decomposable, and if so, how, in section 5.2.) Absolutive case is unmarked. Ergative case is marked with a suffix. The case system shows substantial syncretism; ergative is unmarked (and thus syncretic with absolutive) on pronouns and on plural nouns.[6] Distinguishing between the syntactic features/structures of case and its morphological realization (Legate 2008b), we assume that all transitive subjects are ergative in a syntactic sense, even though those that are pronominal and/or plural will not be realized with visible ergative morphology (modulo the case of possessed nouns).

Data in this paper that is not credited to a specific source was collected in weekly Zoom elicitation sessions between the second author and the third author, a Kalaallisut native speaker who is from Upernavik in northwest Greenland (Avannaata municipality). These sessions were conducted in Danish. Danish prompts and translations were translated into English by the second author. Key data points were cross-checked with a second native speaker from the Qeqertalik municipality further south. All data is archived in [redacted for review].

[6] There is a complication in the case of plural nouns, related to the expression of possession. In possessive constructions, the possessum is marked with a portmanteau morpheme that expresses its case and number as well as the person and number of the possessor. These portmanteaux distinguish between (possesssa in) absolutive vs ergative case, both for singular and for plural. See the paradigms in Fortescue (1984: 206).

2 Kalaallisut has unmarked SOV word order

We begin with a relatively simple argument based on clausal word order. It is typically assumed that word order variation reflects syntactic movement or prosodic reordering triggered by particular features (often information structural ones); in the absence of such features, arguments are linearized according to their highest positions in the basic clause structure. An additional common (though not universal) assumption is that linear precedence and c-command are tightly correlated: A linearly precedes B iff A c-commands B (Kayne 1994). From these premises it follows that languages with a clause structure such as (3) should have unmarked OS order (with verb placement potentially variable), a prediction borne out for languages such as San Mateo Ixtatán Chuj (VOS; Royer 2022). By the same logic, languages with unmarked SO order are those where the object does *not* occupy a position that c-commands the subject in an information-structurally unmarked clause.

It has long been noted that the pragmatically unmarked word order of Kalaallisut is SOV (Fortescue 1984, 1993). The following (elicited and textual) examples illustrate:

(7) a. Piniartu-p puisi pisar-aa
hunter-ERG seal.ABS catch-3SG>3SG.IND
The hunter caught the seal. (Fortescue 1984: 181)

b. Meeqqa-t una angut ikior-paat.
child-PL.ERG DEM.ABS man.ABS help-3PL>3SG.IND
The children helped this man.

c. Erniinnaq meeqqa-t Angutaaluk unngup-paat.
immediately child-PL.ERG Angutaaluk.ABS surround-3PL>3SG.IND
Immediately, the children surrounded Angutaaluk. (From the text *Kalaaq miiraqataalu* (Kalaaq and his friends), §3 ex (2))

The language allows some word order variation, including OSV and SVO, given the right information structure; however, the unmarked status of SOV is uncontroversial and undisputed. This unmarked status is clear in elicitation: in simple translation tasks, the Kalaallisut translation volunteered by our consultants, including the third author, is always SOV, and in judgment tasks, our consultants invariably accept SOV in any context. Evidence from texts reinforces this result. In a study of six Kalaallisut texts, Fortescue (1993) finds SOV order in a range from 72% to 97.5% of transitive clauses depending on the text.[7] He writes that SOV order is "a clearly dominant, pragmatically neutral ordering pattern. Deviation from this - when possible at all - results in specifiable contextual marking" (*ibid.,* 267), i.e. pragmatic effects. In particular, fronting is connected to givenness/topicality of the fronted phrase, whereas postposing applies to phrases that are "specially foregrounded/highlighted material, which may include a New Topic NP, heavy material modifying

[7] The text with SOV in merely 72% of transitive clauses (a political speech) shows a particularly high usage of SVO order. Fortescue writes: "although this speech was presented orally, it contains many examples of long sentences with complex object (and subject) constituents postposed owing to heaviness, typical also of the literary language. The speaker, a bilingual politician, previously a priest, may well have had various Danish turns of expression in mind when he composed it. The style in general could be said to reflect Danish influence on successive clause ordering and the speech contains numerous rather unwieldly glosses of Danish lexical items of a political/administrative sort" (1993: 279-280).

a head NP that may remain within the predication, and other additional clausal or phrasal material of high 'newsworthiness"' (*ibid.,* p 272).

We conclude, then, that Kalaallisut has unmarked SOV word order. Given the assumptions at the top of this section, this suggests that Kalaallisut clause structure does not involve inversion. In line with this conclusion, some previous literature has taken word order as an argument against inversion in Inuit (Bok-Bennema 1991, Wharram 1996, Compton 2018).

Proponents of the inversion analysis have responded to this argument in two ways.[8] For Bittner (1994a), working in a version of GB theory, inversion holds at S-Structure, an abstract syntactic level of representation. In Kalaallisut, word order "may in part be determined by 'scrambling' or 'linearization', at PF. ... the abstract S-Structure of a sentence need not be transparently related to its audible surface form, since the latter is the output of the PF component" (Bittner 1994a: 3). While we do not deny that PF processes might apply to the output of the syntax, it remains unclear to us what specific PF processes could be responsible for mapping a syntactic representation like (3) to an SOV order *by default*. The background assumption here is that PF reordering processes are triggered by particular phonological properties, e.g. prosodic heaviness, and apply only when their triggering factors are present in the input. This matches the picture of prosodic influences on Kalaallisut word order sketched by Fortescue (1993): prosodic heaviness triggers rightward reordering. Crucially, when prosodic reordering processes do *not* apply, the syntactic representation is mapped to linear order based on relations of c-command, as described at the top of this section. If unmarked PF properties reveal unmarked syntax, we conclude that the unmarked syntax of this language has subjects in a higher position than objects.

Largely similar remarks apply to a second previous response to the word order data. Writing of Inuit languages in general, Yuan (2022) suggests that the impact of information structure on word order is so great that no syntactic evidence can be gained here: "in Inuit, the syntactic positions of nominals cannot be easily deduced from word order, which seems to be primarily governed by pragmatic or discourse-related considerations.... Therefore, the movement-based analysis of high abs objects in Inuit does not necessarily induce a change in word order" (Yuan 2022: 517). While we agree that information structure is relevant for word order in Kalaallisut, we find it significant that one specific word order, SOV, is perceived as pragmatically unmarked. That is to say, in a sentence where nothing is specifically topical or focalized, SOV order consistently emerges. It is not clear to us how pragmatic or discourse considerations alone are sufficient to produce this, given a structure like (3); nor is it clear how reordering processes of any nature would be motivated in this case, given the absence of specific information structural features (e.g. focus, topic) on the arguments. If unmarked pragmatics reveals unmarked syntax, we again conclude that the unmarked syntax of this language has subjects in a higher position than objects.

As we close this section, we acknowledge that an inversion analysis of an SOV language of course remains possible if one were to make adjustments to one or more of the premises noted at the top of this section. It could be, for instance, that object movement is necessarily covert in this language (Murasugi 1992). Alternatively, object movement could be overt, but to a rightward specifier, as proposed for syntactically ergative Mayan languages by Little (2020). (To produce SOV, rather than SVO, this would require that the verb also move high and to the right. This has

[8]As a historical note, it is curious that Kalaallisut examples in Bittner 1988 are consistently presented in OSV order. This may have given early inversion theorists the impression that there was no word order puzzle to solve, i.e. no need to respond to the argument just given. Such an impression would explain why early literature did not grapple with this issue and could help explain why it remains discussed relatively little in the literature overall.

been proposed for some verb-final languages, e.g. Korean; see discussion in Han et al. 2007.) On these types of possible analyses, while word order does not yield positive evidence in support of inversion in Kalaallisut, it also does not constitute a problem for an inversion analysis. In the next section we turn to an argument from Condition C effects, where our findings challenge inversion analyses including those positing covert movement and/or rightward specifiers.

3 No Condition C evidence in support of inversion

A clause structure where objects consistently occupy an A-position higher than subjects might be expected to show a distinctive profile as regards Condition C. On one hand, A-movement is classically taken to *bleed* Condition C violations that held in the pre-movement structure, an observation that has spurred a large literature; see the English example with raising to subject in (8). On the other hand, A-movement also appears to *feed* Condition C violations in the derived position, as shown in the English examples in (9).[9]

(8) a. Baseline: *It seemed to her$_i$ that [the children that Naja$_i$ took home] were hungry.
(Coreference between *her* and *Naja* excluded by Condition C)

b. [The children that Naja$_i$ took home] seemed to her$_i$ __ to be hungry.
(Bleeding of Condition C: Coreference between *her* and *Naja* permitted)

(9) a. Baseline: It seemed to [the children that Naja$_i$ took home] that she$_i$ was kind.
(No Condition C violation)

b. *She$_i$ seemed to [the children that Naja$_i$ took home] __ to be kind.
(Feeding of Condition C: Coreference between *her* and *Naja* excluded)

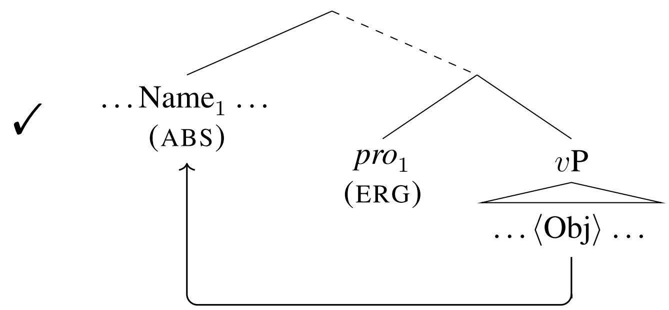
These predictions are applied to inversion structures in Malagasy by Paul (2002) and in Chuj and Mandar by Royer (2022), Brodkin (2022), Brodkin and Royer (2024). Let us first consider the predicted pattern of Condition C bleeding. As expected, in all three languages, inversion bleeds Condition C violations that would otherwise occur when a subject pronominal is co-indexed with an R-expression inside the object. In the Malagasy example in (10), movement of the object *ny zana-dRakoto* 'Rakoto's child' takes it past the pronominal subject (expressed in Malagasy as a verbal suffix, *-ny*). Abstracting away from linear order, the relevant structure is schematized in (11).[10]

(10) Notambaza-ny$_i$ ariary folo [ny zana-dRakoto$_i$].
PST.TT.hire-GEN.3 ariary ten DET child.GEN.Rakoto
He$_i$ hired Rakoto$_i$'s child for 10 ariary. (Malagasy; Paul 2002)

[9] Other cases of A-movement feeding Condition C are discussed in Paul (2002), Deal (2013), Brodkin (2022), Brodkin and Royer (2024).

[10] Malagasy poses the same word order challenge as does Kalaallisut; its word order is generally VSO. To derive the word order in Malagasy, Guilfoyle et al. (1992) treat the derived position of the object as a rightward specifier; Pearson (2001) posits leftward predicate fronting. We abstract away from this issue here. Note that in Malagasy, inversion takes place in clauses with 'Theme Topic' morphology (TT in glosses), though not in those without. We concentrate here on the structure of these TT clauses.

(11) Inversion bleeds Condition C violations in the object (Malagasy, Chuj, Mandar)



Overall, the Malagasy, Chuj, and Mandar data are parallel to the English example in (8), showing that A-movement need not reconstruct for Condition C (see also Legate (2014) for Acehnese).

This pattern cannot be replicated in Kalaallisut. In (12), the subject is *pro* (the unmarked form for subject pronominals to take) and the object is an overt DP. Because the subject is null, there is no word order evidence here that would force the subject to occupy a particular structural position relative to the object. Moreover, the object contains a relative clause, which could in principle be merged relatively early or relatively late.[11] The impossibility of the coreferential reading, where the subject refers to Naja, shows that no parse is available that obviates Condition C.

(12) Aqagu [atuagaq ippassaq Naja-p pisiari-gaa] atua-ssu-vaa.
tomorrow [book.ABS yesterday Naja-ERG buy-3SG>3SG.PART] read-FUT-3SG>3SG
Tomorrow she$_{j/*i}$ will read [the book Naja$_i$ bought yesterday].

The contrast between these data and the data from Malagasy, Chuj, and Mandar provides *prima facie* support for the idea that Kalaallisut, unlike these other languages, does not obligatorily A-move its objects above the subject.

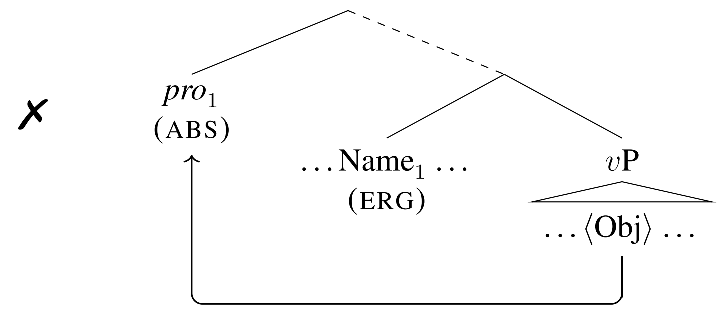
We now consider the predicted pattern of Condition C feeding. As expected on an inversion analysis, in Malagasy and Mandar, inversion feeds Condition C violations when a pronominal object comes to c-command a coindexed R-expression inside the subject.[12] Consider the Malagasy example in (13). Here the object *izy* moves over the subject *ny rain-dRakoto* 'Rakoto's father', establishing a c-command relation between *izy* and the name *Rakoto*. The result is a Condition C violation. Again abstracting away from linear order, this structure is schematized in (14).

(13) * Notambazan'-ny rain-dRakoto$_i$ izy$_i$.
PST.TT.hire.GEN father.GEN.Rakoto 3(NOM)
Rakoto$_i$'s father hired him$_i$. (Paul 2002)

[11]For a recent discussion (and defense) of late merger of adjuncts, see Zyman (2022).

[12]Royer (2022) notes that this prediction is difficult to assess for Chuj due to an anticataphora constraint operative in that language. This confound does not apply to Mandar or Malagasy, as far as we are aware.

(14) Inversion feeds Condition C violations in the subject (Malagasy, Mandar)



The Malagasy and Mandar data are parallel to the English example in (9), showing that A-movement cannot use reconstruction to avoid a Condition C violation.

This pattern cannot be reproduced for Kalaallisut either. Pronominal objects in this language may be freely coindexed with R-expressions inside the subject, as we see in the examples in (15).[13]

(15) a. [Naja-p pani-ata] ikior-paa.
[Naja-ERG daughter-3SG>3SG.ERG] help-3SG>3SG.IND
Naja$_i$'s daughter helped her$_i$.

b. [Meeqqa-t Naja-mik qani-si-sut] ikior-paat.
[child-PL Naja-INST take.home-AP-3PL.PART] help-3PL>3SG
The children that took Naja$_i$ home helped her$_i$.

These data again suggest, at least *prima facie*, that objects do not obligatorily move above subjects in Kalaallisut, in contrast to the situation in Malagasy and Mandar.

At the conclusion of the previous section, we noted that two possible responses to the default SOV order of Kalaallisut available to an inversion theorist were to posit covert object movement or to posit movement to a rightward specifier. We note that neither of these possible analyses explains the absence of Condition C bleeding and feeding effects. Malagasy is like Kalaallisut in showing SO order, and this order is analyzed with rightward specifiers by Paul (2000); however Malagasy in contrast to Kalaallisut shows the Condition C feeding and bleeding patterns associated with object movement over the subject. In terms of covert movement, while we are not aware of work on bleeding of Condition C, Deal (2013) shows that covert A-movement at least feeds Condition C in Nez Perce.

This leaves two remaining possibilities. One is that there is simply no inversion, as suggested above: the Kalaallisut clauses considered in this section strictly have the non-inversion structure in (4), rather than obligatory inversion as in (3) or even optional inversion as in (5). Because the object cannot A-move past the subject, a structure with a pronominal subject coindexed with an R-expression in the object invariably triggers a Condition C effect, (12), and a structure with a pronominal object coindexed with an R-expression in the subject invariably does not, (15).

Another possibility is that A-movement of objects over subjects does take place in this language, but this movement (unlike its counterparts in Malagasy, Chuj, and Mandar) obligatorily reconstructs for Condition C. For this type of approach to be attractive, we would need some general way of predicting whether a language with inversion does or not show obligatory Condition

[13]The coindexation patterns noted in these examples are those that are relevant for the argument here. It is also possible for the object to refer to an individual other than Naja, of course.

C reconstruction. A theory with appropriate generality can be found in recent work on scrambling in Hindi (Keine and Bhatt 2025) and Mongolian (Gong 2025). We exemplify here with Hindi. In Hindi, as noted in the introduction, objects may move past subjects. Clause-internal scrambling of the object over the subject may behave like A-movement in that it feeds pronominal and reciprocal binding (Mahajan 1990, Bhatt 2016, Keine 2020, Keine and Bhatt 2025). However, it does not bleed Condition C.[14] Thus in (16a), movement of the object *Sita-ke bhaaii-ko* 'Sita's brother' over the subject pronominal does not make it possible for that pronominal and *Sita* to corefer. The example shows the same Condition C violation as the version without object scrambling, (16b).

(16) Hindi (Keine and Bhatt 2025)

a. [Sita-ke$_1$ bhaaii-ko]$_2$ us-ne$_{3/*1}$ ___$_2$ ḍããṭaa.
   Sita-GEN brother-ACC she-ERG scolded
   Intended: 'Sita's$_1$ brother, she$_1$ scolded.'

b. Us-ne$_{2/*1}$ [Sita-ke$_1$ bhaaii-ko] ḍããṭaa.
   she-ERG Sita-GEN brother-ACC scolded
   Intended: 'She$_1$ scolded Sita's$_1$ brother.'

That the subject cannot refer to Sita in (16a) shows that there is no parse available on which inverting movement of the object over the subject has bled Condition C. These data contrast with examples like Malagasy (10), where inverting movement of the object over the subject *does* bleed Condition C.

Building on Takahashi and Hulsey (2009), Keine and Bhatt (2025) posit that the crucial factor at play here is abstract case assignment. (Gong 2025 draws the same conclusion for Mongolian.) In Hindi, the object is assigned its case prior to scrambling, i.e. in a low structural position. Assignment of case in a low position forces the copy of the object in that low position to be evaluated for Condition C.[15] Even if a higher copy of the object does not trigger a Condition C violation, the copy in a low position will do so. Thus, object movement does not bleed Condition C. For a language like Malagasy, Chuj, or Mandar, where object movement does bleed Condition C, this suggests that the object is assigned case only after it has moved above the subject. This analysis comports nicely with analyses of Malagasy, Chuj, and Mandar according to which object movement over the subject is necessary for the object to receive its case—that is, the object receives its case in a structurally high position, the position obtained by movement (Guilfoyle et al. 1992, Paul 2000, Royer 2022, Brodkin 2022, Brodkin and Royer 2024).[16] The general expectation that

[14] It is hard to test whether this movement feeds Condition C, i.e. creates a Condition C violation. In order to see a Condition C violation emerge in OSV order, it would need to be the case that the only way that OSV order is derived is by movement that feeds Condition C. In Hindi, this precondition does not hold. Internal to a single clause, an object that moves over the subject may have Ā scrambled or A scrambled (Mahajan 1990); OSV order is thus derivationally ambiguous. Ā-movement is not expected to create a Condition C violation. Therefore, even if there is a OSV parse that creates a Condition C violation, the parse that does *not* violate Condition C will remain available, and no ungrammaticality is expected.

[15] For the mechanics of how this works, see Keine and Bhatt (2025) (who build on Takahashi 2006, Takahashi and Hulsey 2009, Thoms and Heycock 2022).

[16] This is also the analysis that van Urk (2015) arrives at for Dinka, a language where the relevant movement has mixed A/A' properties. In this language, too, movement of the object over the subject bleeds Condition C; van Urk concludes that case is assigned in a high position. This finding makes clear that even if obligatory inversion in Kalaallisut were mixed A/A' movement in some sense (however this might be cashed out), we would still expect an effect on Condition C so long as case is assigned in the derived position.

emerges is that inversion will feed/bleed Condition C in languages where objects receive case high (above the subject) but not in those where objects receive case low (below the subject).[17] This clarifies the nature of the possible inversion analysis of Kalaallisut that remains compatible with the Condition C data we have seen in this section. It may still be that objects obligatorily move over subjects in the clause structure of this language, but case assignment to the object must occur in a low position, *not* the position obtained by the inverting movement.

We note that this conclusion contrasts quite strikingly with previous work on both Kalaallisut and other Inuit languages. From Bittner (1988) onward, work positing inversion in Inuit languages has consistently posited either a case-based motivation for object movement (as in Murasugi 1992, Bittner 1994a, Bittner and Hale 1996a,b, Manga 1996) or else a calculus of case that considers the high position of the object (Yuan 2018, 2022, 2026). Our Condition C data suggest that these ways of connecting inversion and case assignment cannot be maintained. Either there is simply no inversion in Kalaallisut basic clause structure, or else there is inversion of a type that applies to nominals whose case has already been determined.[18]

We venture at this point an interim summary. In considering word order and Condition C effects, we have failed to turn up any evidence in favor of an inversion analysis. The data is instead most straightforwardly interpreted as evidence against an inversion analysis. While we do not claim to have totally eliminated all possibility of an inversion analysis, the data we have seen severely delimit the types of inversion analyses that remain viable. Inversion must be linearly invisible in clauses with default word order (if not elsewhere). And it must be essentially "invisible" for Condition C as well, i.e. unable to feed or bleed Condition C; we take this to indicate that it is not connected to case assignment. We note that, in the absence of some other clear trigger for an inversion analysis, this profile overall makes it hard to imagine how a language learner might come to adopt an obligatory inversion analysis of this language.

4 No ban on hyperraising of ergative subjects

Recent literature has seen an increasingly wide range of languages shown to permit hyperraising, i.e. A-movement out of a finite clause.[19] One such language is Kalaallisut (Mikkelsen and Thrane 2024, Mikkelsen et al. 2026). In this section we use hyperraising as a tool to diagnose the basic clause structure of the language. The logic is as follows: a clause structure where objects consistently occupy an A-position higher than subjects is expected to show a distinctive profile as regards hyperraising. As A-movement, hyperraising applies only to the highest DP in the clause. If objects are consistently the highest DP in a transitive clause, we expect that only objects will be able

[17] There is a further correlation with movement of the object that is obligatory vs. optional. In Hindi, movement is unrelated to case and is optional. Movement is arguably related to case, and is obligatory, in Chuj and Mandar (and under certain circumstances in Malagasy). We will return to the question of whether there is optional object movement in Kalaallisut also in the next section.

[18] Yuan (2018, 2022, 2026) proposes that ergative case in Inuit languages is a dependent case assigned downward to the subject in an inversion structure. In her system, nominals whose case has already been determined are not visible for case assignment rules; therefore, assignment of case to the object before inversion would make it impossible for the object to trigger ergative on the subject after movement. We note that it remains possible that ergative is a dependent case in Kalaallisut, so long as the assignment of ergative does not involve inversion; a version of the analysis in Clem and Deal (To appear) may be applicable, for instance.

[19] See e.g. Ura 1996, Rodrigues 2004, Ferreira 2004, Nevins 2004, Zeller 2006, Carstens 2011, Carstens and Diercks 2013, Asarina 2011, Halpert 2016, 2019, Deal 2017a, Zyman 2017, Fong 2019, Jenks 2025.

to hyperraise. Hyperraising of transitive subjects should be ungrammatical. As we will see, this expectation is not borne out.

We begin with background on hyperraising structures in Kalaallisut. Mikkelsen and Thrane (2024) show that Kalaallisut structures like (17) involve hyperraising to object: *illit* 'you' originates as the subject of the lower clause and A-moves into the matrix, where it agrees like the object of the matrix verb. Here and in the following examples, we use boldface to indicate the argument that has hyperraised in the Kalaallisut sentence, as well as the corresponding argument in the English translation. In example (17), the matrix agreement suffix *-vakkit* is a portmanteau for 1sg subject and 2sg object (indicative mood). We note the gap in the embedded clause as ABS because the raising DP is the intransitive subject of the embedded clause.

(17) **Illit** eqqaama-vakkit [$_{CP}$ ___$_{\text{ABS}}$ angerla-jaar-tutit].
2SG.ABS remember-1SG>$\boxed{\text{2SG}}$.IND [leave-early-2SG.PART]
I remember that **you** left early.

The data that will be key for our argument in this section are of the form in (18). Here, the argument that has hyperraised corresponds to the subject of the embedded transitive clause. Accordingly, we note the gap with ERG. Once again, the raising argument agrees like the object of the matrix verb. Here *vakka* in the matrix clause is a portmanteau for 1sg subject and 3pl object (indicative mood).

(18) **Meeqqa-t** eqqaama-vakka [$_{CP}$ ___$_{\text{ERG}}$ illit ikior-aatsit]
child-PL remember-1SG>$\boxed{\text{3PL}}$.IND [2SG.ABS help-3PL>2SG.PART]
'I remember that **the children** helped you.' (Mikkelsen and Thrane 2024)

In principle, structures like (17)-(18) could involve movement of *illit* / *meeqqat* into the matrix clause, or base-generation there. The former is the analysis we endorse (hyperraising); we could use the term 'prolepsis' to describe the latter type of analysis. Evidence that the Kalaallisut pattern arises from movement, rather than prolepsis, comes from three main sources (Mikkelsen and Thrane 2024). First, the construction in question requires a gap in the embedded clause. Plugging the gap with an overt pronoun results in ungrammaticality.[20] We show this below both for hyperraising of an intransitive subject and of a transitive subject.[21]

(19) a. **Illit** eqqaama-vakkit [***illit** / ✓___$_{\text{ABS}}$ angerla-jaar-tutit].
2SG.ABS remember-1SG>2SG [2SG.ABS / leave-early-2SG.PRT]
I remember that you left early.

b. **Illit** eqqaama-vakkit [***illit** / ✓___$_{\text{ERG}}$ ikior-itit].
2SG.ABS remember-1SG>2SG [2SG.ERG / help-2SG>3PL.PRT]
I remember that you helped them.

We note in general that the tests for movement vs. prolepsis that we have been able to apply yield the same results (in favor of movement) both for examples that involve a transitive subject position in the lower clause (such as (18), (19b)) and for those that involve other types of lower clause argument positions, e.g. intransitive subject (as in (17), (19a)).

[20]On the contrast with prolepsis on this point and the points below, we refer the reader to Salzmann (2017).

[21]Recall that pronouns in Kalaallisut do not show morphological case distinctions; thus both abstractly absolutive and abstractly ergative 2SG subjects surface as *illit*.

A second source of evidence for movement comes from island-sensitivity. Example (20) shows that the construction in question is sensitive to the coordinate structure constraint: the position in the embedded clause connected with the raised argument cannot be inside a coordination.

(20) * Naja-p Hansi-l-lu **uanga** malugi-vaannga $[_{CP}$ tamatigut [___$_{\text{ERG}}$
Naja-ERG Hansi-ERG-and 1SG.ABS notice-3PL>1SG.IND [always [
Juuna-l-lu] qimmi-t nerukkar-ivut].
Juuna-ERG-and] dog-PL.ABS feed-1PL>3PL.PART].
Intended: Naja and Hansi noticed that **me** and Juuna always feed the dogs.

Similarly, example (21) shows sensitivity to the left-branch condition: the position in the embedded clause connected with the raised argument cannot be a possessor.

(21) * **Illit** eqqaama-vakkit $[_{CP}$ ippassaq $[_{DP}$ ___$_{\text{GEN}}$ erner-pit]
2SG.ABS remember-1SG>2SG.IND [yesterday son-2SG>3SG.ERG
meeqqa-t ikior-ai].
child-PL.ABS help-3SG>3PL.PART]
Intended: I remember that **your son** helped the children yesterday.

A third source of evidence for movement rather than prolepsis comes from locality effects, in particular those that can be seen in multiple embedding. The key aspect of the hyperraising construction we draw on here is the fact that the raising element agrees like an object in the clause into which it moves. In multi-embedding structures, hyperraising in Kalaallisut may cross multiple clauses. Example (22a), for instance, has the general structure indicated in (22b).[22] *Meeqqat* 'the children' begins in the most embedded clause, moves through the medial clause, and finally surfaces in the matrix clause. In each clause through which it moves, it agrees like an object. Thus we see the agreement suffix *-gai* (3sg on 3pl) in the medial clause, and *-lakka* (1sg on 3pl) in the matrix clause. The presence of 3rd person plural agreement in the medial clause provides a clear signal that *meeqqat* 'the children' has moved through this clause.

(22) Cyclic hyperraising:

a. **Meeqqa-t** nalunngi-lakka [Juuna-p ___ eqqaama-gai [
child-PL.ABS know-1SG>$\boxed{\text{3PL}}$.IND [Juuna-ERG remember-3SG>$\boxed{\text{3PL}}$.PART [
Naja-p ___ ikior-ai]]
Naja-ERG help-3SG>$\boxed{\text{3PL}}$.PART]]
I know that Juuna remembers that Naja helped the children.

b. I the children know [Juuna *t* remembers [Naja *t* helped]]

We contrast this example with a minimally different sentence in which the medial verb lacks 3PL object agreement.[23] This is ungrammatical.

[22] What is key here is that hyperraising into the highest clause involves hyperraising into the medial clause. We set aside questions as to whether additional movement through the CP edge is also needed.

[23] If there is not an object hyperraising into the medial ('remember') clause, there are two possible configurations that might be expected. One is that object agreement is with the clausal argument of 'remember', which is 3SG; this is the form we show here. The other is that there is no object agreement at all in the medial clause (and no ergative on the subject *Juuna*). This yields ungrammaticality in this example as well.

(23) Skipping middle clause:

a.

* **Meeqqa-t**	nalunngi-lakka	[Juuna-p	eqqaama-gaa	[	
child-PL.ABS	know-1SG>3PL.IND	[Juuna-ERG	remember-3SG>3SG.PART	[	
Naja-p	___	ikior-ai	]]		
Naja-ERG		help-3SG>3PL.PART	]]		

I know that Juuna remembers that Naja helped the children.

b. * I the children know [Juuna remembers [Naja *t* helped]]

The movement analysis provides a straightforward explanation of this contrast. On a movement analysis, the structure of (23a) would need to be as in (23b). This structure is ruled out because the movement in question is too long.[24] The contrast between (22) and (23) is thus the contrast between successive cyclic movement (grammatical; (22)) and "one fell swoop" movement (ungrammatical; (23)).

Thus far we have argued that the sentences under discussion in this section involve movement rather than prolepsis. There is evidence that this movement is, in particular, A-movement. It feeds case and agreement: the hyperraised nominal controls object agreement on the upstairs verb, and whatever its case would have been downstairs, the hyperraised nominal shows absolutive in the upstairs clause (like other objects).[25] Furthermore, this movement applies only to DPs – e.g. adverbs cannot be hyperraised. In (24), for instance, there is no reading available on which the adverb *qangali* 'long since' is associated with the embedded clause.

(24)

Qangali	nassuiar-para	Naja	angerla-toq.
long.since	explain-1SG>3SG.IND	Naja.ABS	leave-3SG.PART

a. ✓I long since explained that Naja left.

b. ✗I explained that Naja long since left.

Lastly, as noted by Mikkelsen and Thrane (2024), this construction is insensitive to Ā features. Topics, foci, and *wh*'s all *can* be hyperraised, and there is no information-structurally determined category of nominals that *must* be hyperraised. This indicates that Kalaallisut hyperraising is not 'mixed' A/Ā-movement; rather, it behaves like pure A-movement on all applicable tests.[26]

We are now ready to return to the argument concerning inversion introduced at the top of this section. We take A-movement to be driven by probes that attract the closest DP in an A-position. If the object must occupy an A-position higher than the subject in the Kalaallisut transitive clause, we expect only objects to be able to hyperraise from transitive clauses. This, as we have seen, is false. We repeat a relevant example in (25).

(25)

Meeqqa-t	eqqaama-vakka	[$_{CP}$ __$_{\text{ERG}}$	illit	ikior-aatsit]
child-PL.ABS	remember-1SG>3PL.IND	[	2SG.ABS	help-3PL>2SG.PART]

'I remember that **the children** helped you.' (Mikkelsen & Thrane 2023)

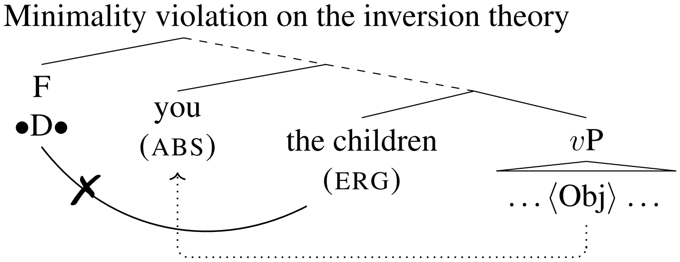
[24] Any principle of absolute locality, e.g. the phase impenetrability condition, could be used to explain this.

[25] Hyperaising involves movement between case positions; see Béjar and Massam (1999).

[26] Condition C tests are not readily applicable here as hyperraising does not move DPs over other DP positions.

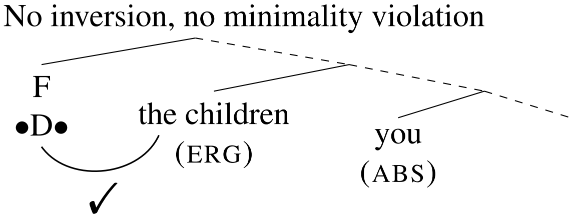
On the inversion theory, hyperraising in (25) violates minimality. To make this precise, suppose hyperraising is driven by a probe on some head, call it F; this head attracts the highest DP. (We use the • notation of Müller (2010) to indicate a probe that drives movement.) F can attract the object, but it cannot attract the subject. Thus (25) is predicted ungrammatical.

(26) Minimality violation on the inversion theory



We are not aware of any version of an inversion analysis which provides a satisfactory analysis of these data. We cannot, for instance, appeal to case to explain why the object is skipped by the F-probe; absolutives are certainly themselves able to hyperraise, as seen above, which means the probe must be able to see them. (Furthermore, absolutive as an 'unmarked' case is typologically unlikely to be invisible to case-sensitive probes; see Bobaljik (2008).). We cannot treat the F probe as sensitive to particular ϕ-features, as we see no hierarchy effects in hyperraising (e.g. person hierarchy effects); nor is it sensitive to information structural features, as noted above. The analysis that remains viable is one where Kalaallisut clause structure does not force inversion. *Without* inversion, it is structurally unsurprising that hyperraising can apply to ergatives. Maintaining the same assumptions about what drives hyperraising, in a clause without inversion, hyperraising of the ergative subject is expected to proceed straightforwardly.

(27) No inversion, no minimality violation



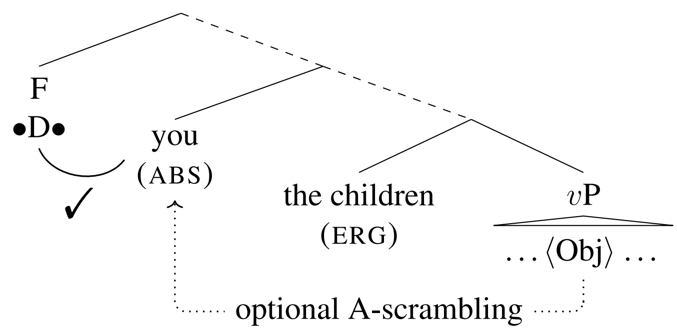
We now look to hyperraising data for perspective on the question of whether Kalaallisut allows objects to invert with subjects even *optionally*, granting that it does not do so *obligatorily*. We saw in the previous section that the Condition C behavior seen in Kalaallisut is also found in Hindi, a language that allows objects to A-scramble over subjects. We concluded the previous section with two analyses still viable. First, it could be that Kalaallisut entirely lacks inversion, whether obligatory or optional. Second, it could be that Kalaallisut has inversion with the same Condition C profile as Hindi (i.e. Condition C reconstruction is obligatory). In Hindi, as noted above, this inversion is optional: an A-scrambling parse is available only with overt OS order (in contrast to the neutral word order, which is SOV). Could Kalaallisut be like Hindi in having optional inversion, available only in a subset of structures e.g. those with overt OS order? Such an approach is compatible with the data of the previous two sections. Hyperraising provides an empirical test. If an object *can* occupy the highest A-position in the clause, we expect that it *can* hyperraise. This prediction is correct.

Consider the sentence in (28). What has hyperraised here is *Juuna Kaali-lu* 'Juuna and Kaali', which is interpreted as the object of the embedded clause. The subject of the embedded clause, ergative-marked *Najap* 'Naja', remains in situ in the lower clause. This shows that objects as well as subjects may hyperraise in Kalaallisut.

(28) [**Juuna** **Kaali-lu**] eqqaama-vakka [___ABS Naja-p ikior-ai].
[Juuna.ABS Kaali.ABS-and] remember-1SG>3SG.IND [Naja-ERG help-HELP-3SG>3PL.PART]
I remember that Naja helped **Juuna and Kaali**.

Accounting for this data requires a parse to be available on which the embedded object occupies the highest A-position in the embedded clause. We take this position to be obtained via optional A-scrambling, as shown in (29).

(29)



Optional A-scrambling allows us to make sense of the fact that hyperraising may target either subjects or objects of transitive clauses. Either one may be the highest DP in the clause, depending on whether A-scrambling has taken place. The feeding relation between object scrambling and hyperraising further confirms that movement of the object over the subject, when it does happen, is indeed A-movement in Kalaallisut. Given the ban on Improper Movement, we expect only A-movement to be able to feed further A-movement such as hyperraising.

To summarize, in this section we have demonstrated a hyperraising construction in Kalaallisut and used it to argue against an obligatory inversion analysis as in (3). Obligatory inversion predicts that ergative subjects should be unable to hyperraise. This prediction is incorrect. What we find in Kalaallisut is in fact that both transitive subjects and transitive objects are available to hyperraising (though of course not at the same time!). Such data suggest that Kalaallisut may be best analyzed as a language with optional inversion, (5), in the same way as a language like Hindi. As noted in the introduction, this type of approach is similar to an approach entirely without inversion in that it does not allow us to appeal to inversion as an account of the EEC.[27]

[27] Our finding that Kalaallisut absolutives optionally invert stands in contrast to the picture presented in Yuan (2022) concerning object movement and variation across Inuit varieties. Yuan proposes that all objects invert in Kalaallisut; we discuss (and reject) the reasons for this proposal in the following section. She proposes that an apparent 'cline of ergativity' in Inuit languages—with Kalaallisut as 'most ergative', Labrador Inuttut as 'least ergative', and Inuktitut in between—largely turns on the question of which objects raise in the different varieties: in Kalaallisut, all objects raise, meaning ergative is always available in transitives; in Labrador Inuttut, only pronouns raise, meaning ergative is only available when the object is pronominal. Our findings suggest two alternative ways of approaching these findings. The first involves no movement. We suggested in fn 18 that Kalaallisut ergative could be handled on the approach in Clem and Deal (To appear). On that theory, dependent case marks the second ϕ-goal of a probe. Suppose that the relevant ϕ-probe can always find a second goal in Kalaallisut, but in Labrador Inuttut, the probe can only proceed

5 Revising previous arguments for inversion

In the previous three sections we have argued against obligatory inversion in the basic clause structure of Kalaallisut. Our conclusion stands in contrast with a sizable body of previous work on Kalaallisut and related Inuit languages that posits inversion, e.g. Bittner (1988, 1994a), Murasugi (1992, 1997), Bittner and Hale (1996a,b), Manga (1996), Wharram (2003), Spreng (2006), Yuan (2018, 2021, 2022).[28] Three arguments for inversion are prominent in this literature. One is an argument from scope: inversion is necessary to account for the particular scopal properties of absolutives. The next concerns affix order: inversion is necessary in order to properly explain the morphology of verbal agreement. The third is simply the claim that inversion is necessary to derive the EEC. Since we are interested in this paper in exactly the question of whether inversion *is* necessary to derive the EEC, we set aside this third argument and focus here on the first two. We will show that neither argument makes a compelling case in favor of inversion in light of additional data and of modern frameworks for understanding agreement and scope.

5.1 Scope: no support for inversion

The argument for inversion from scope originates with Bittner's early work (Bittner 1987, 1988) and is cited by essentially all subsequent research arguing for inversion in Inuit, including Murasugi (1992, 1997), Bittner (1994a), Bittner and Hale (1996a,b), Manga (1996) and Yuan (2018, 2021, 2022). The core data behind this argument are as follows. In Kalaallisut, absolutive arguments cannot take scope below clausemate sentential operators, such as negation. This is shown for *atuagaq ataaseq* 'one book' as an intransitive subject in (30a) and as a transitive object in (30b). In both cases, an interpretation on which the indefinite scopes over negation is available, but scope under negation is not possible.

(30) Bittner (1994a: 2), orthography updated

a. Atuagaq ataaseq tikis-sima-nngi-la-q
   book one come-PRF-NEG-IND-3SG

   i. ✓There is a book that has not come.
   ii. ✗It is not the case that a book has come.

to a second goal if the object is pronominal. Thus ergative will occur generally in transitives in Kalaallisut but only with pronominal objects in Labrador Inuttut. The second possibility is that there *is* object movement, but of a very short, non-inverting form (as in Johnson 1991, for instance). Objects that undergo this short movement trigger ergative on the subject (which could be handled via a variety of dependent case theories); those that remain in situ do not. In Kalaallisut, all objects undergo this short movement, but in Labrador Inuttut, only pronouns do. On this type of approach, hyperraising of an object in Kalaallisut would involve a first, very short movement step (e.g. to Spec,μP, in Johnson's terms), followed by inverting A-scrambling, followed by cross-clausal movement.

[28] There has been some work defending an inversion-less clause structure, though this has certainly been a minority view; see Bok-Bennema (1991), Pittman (2006). There is also some work that posits inversion (object movement past the subject, or in the case of Johns (1992), base-generation of the object higher than the subject) plus re-inversion (subject movement past the high object position), incorporating both views. See e.g. Johns (1992), Bobaljik (1993), Wharram (1996).

b. Juuna-p atuagaq ataaseq tigu-sima-nngi-laa
Juuna-ERG book one get-PRF-NEG-IND-3SG>3SG

i. ✓There is a book that Juuna has not gotten.
ii. ✗It is not the case that Juuna has gotten a book.

We first present the argument linking these data to the syntax of the object, which we summarize with the slogan “scope-taking is only by movement”. We then respond to this argument in two ways. First, we note that these data instantiate the general phenomenon of obligatory wide scope indefinites, which are standardly analyzed in the contemporary literature with choice functions (Matthewson 1999, Wharram 2003, Lidz 2006, Branigan and Wharram 2019, Dawson 2020, among many others). As Wharram (2003) argues, this provides a way of understanding the scope behavior of Kalaallisut absolutives without appeal to syntactic movement—scope and inversion are decoupled, and obligatory wide scope does *not* require the object to move over the subject. Second, following Wharram, we show that when we compare the only-by-movement approach and the choice-functional approach head-to-head, the choice-functional approach makes superior predictions. It straightforwardly explains the ability of absolutives to take scope outside of scope islands, and allows for a simple approach to absolutive negative polarity items (NPIs) which avoids stipulations otherwise required by Bittner’s (1994a) approach. At the end of this section, we will also show how it casts light on new data suggesting (*contra* Bittner 1994a) that absolutives and ergatives behave the same way in their scope taking behavior.

5.1.1 Distinguishing two analyses

We first aim to clarify the argument linking scope to inversion for data like (30). While Bittner’s original formulation was cast in GB theory terms, a modern reconstruction of the argument might be given as follows.[29] First, all Kalaallisut absolutive descriptions have generalized quantifier semantics, as in (31).[30] Second, absolutive descriptions take scope strictly via movement (and cannot reconstruct).

(31) Scope-only-by-movement theory: interpretation of the absolutive object
$[\![$*atuagaq ataaseq* ‘one book.ABS’$]\!] = \lambda P.\exists x[books(x) \wedge |x| = 1 \wedge P(x)]$

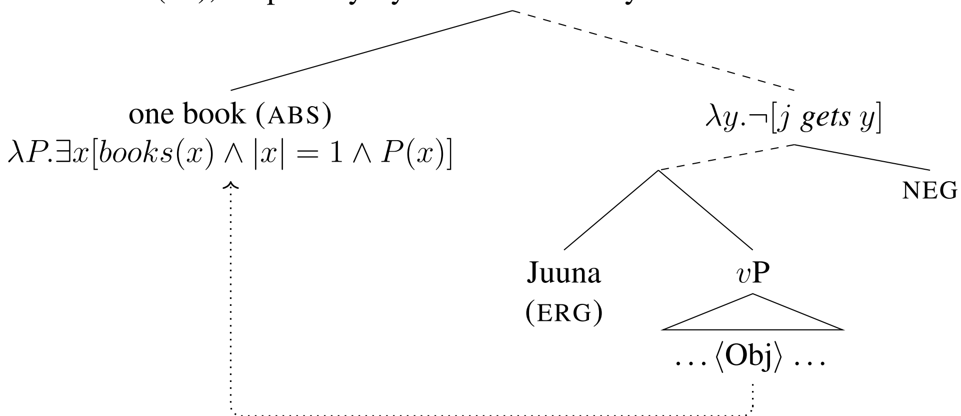
It follows that movement of absolutives above sentential operators is necessary and sufficient to capture their scope behavior. On this theory, the structure of (30b) (repeated below) is shown in (33). In its high position, the quantificational object composes with its sister, which includes the semantic negation. The result is that the existential quantifier introduced by the object outscopes negation.

(32) Juuna-p atuagaq ataaseq tigu-sima-nngi-laa
Juuna-ERG book one get-PRF-NEG-IND-3SG>3SG
There is a book that Juuna has not gotten.

[29] This closely mirrors the presentation in Yuan (2018: 250).

[30] The term ‘description’ here is intended to single out nominals that are not names or pronouns. These are the elements for which one can ask questions about scope. Generalized quantifiers are elements whose semantics relates two sets of individuals.

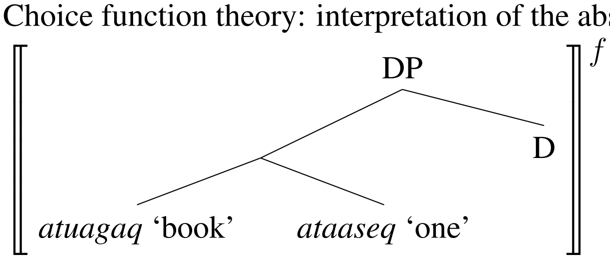
(33) Structure of (32), scope-only-by-movement theory



For this argument to go through, it is crucial that the slogan holds: *scope-taking is only by movement*. The interpretation of *atuagaq ataaseq* 'one book.ABS' must *only* be as in (31), and the structure of (32) must be *only* as in (33). There must be no mechanism by which the quantifier associated with 'book' could scope over negation *without* movement of the object. The essential challenge for the argument from scope is that there is indeed such a mechanism—one that is formally well-understood, widely adopted in the literature, and even explicitly defended specifically for Kalaallisut by Wharram (2003). This mechanism is choice functions.

A choice function is a function which applies to a (nonempty) set and returns a member of that set.[31] In developing a choice-functional account of indefinite scope in Kalaallisut and Inuktitut, Wharram (2003) suggests that indefinites in these languages are, fundamentally, predicative expressions. To serve as an absolutive object, the predicative indefinite combines with a silent determiner that introduces a choice function variable.[32] This means that in our working example (again repeated below in (35)), the overall DP object *atuagaq ataaseq* 'one book' is not analyzed as a generalized quantifier. It is instead treated as a type e expression, i.e. as a referential term. Relative to a choice of functions f, given by the context of interpretation, it picks out a particular element that has the property of being one book.

(34) Choice function theory: interpretation of the absolutive object



$= f(\lambda x.books(x) \wedge |x| = 1)$

As a type e expression, *atuagaq ataaseq* 'one book' may freely remain in situ at LF (that is, it does not need to move for reasons of semantic type). The choice-functional variable it introduces may

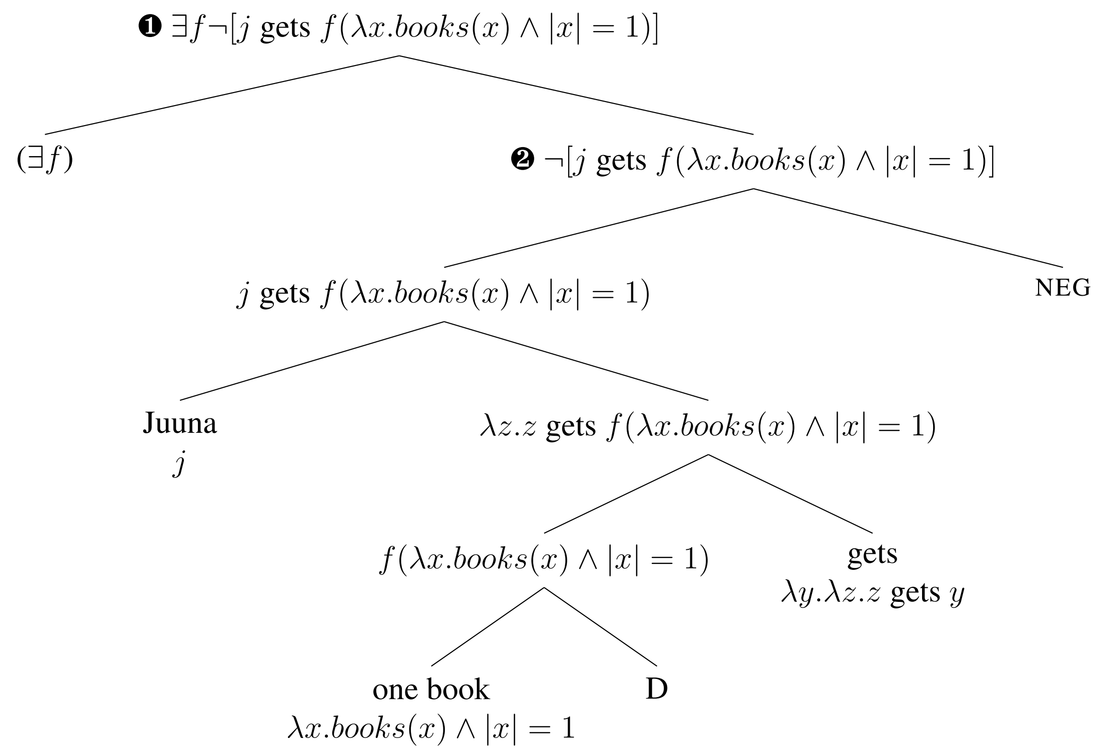
[31] Foundational references here are Reinhart (1997), Winter (1997), Kratzer (1998).

[32] This approach is further developed in Branigan and Wharram (2019). Both Wharram (2003) and Branigan and Wharram (2019) discuss both this derivation for absolutive indefinite objects and an alternative, non-choice-function-based derivation for non-absolutive (modalis) objects. Modalis objects do not show obligatory wide scope and thus have not played a role in arguing for inversion; they therefore fall outside the scope of our discussion here. Empirical and theoretical discussion of their behavior across Inuit varieties may be found in Bittner (1987, 1994a), Wharram (2003), Branigan and Wharram (2019), Yuan (2022).

either be left free (as Wharram argues, following Kratzer 1998) or existentially closed at the edge of the clause (an option defended for other languages by Matthewson 1999, Dawson 2020). In tree (36), we show both of these options, parenthesizing a $\exists f$ element at the left periphery. If the choice function variable is left free, the sentence denotation is as given at the node labeled ❷; if there is existential closure, it is as given at the node labeled ❶. We discuss these meanings immediately below. Note that on either approach, the structure does not involve inversion.

(35) Juuna-p atuagaq ataaseq tigu-sima-nngi-laa
Juuna-ERG book one get-PRF-NEG-IND-3SG>3SG
There is a book that Juuna has not gotten.

(36) Structure of (35), choice function theory



A choice function provides a way of picking out an object from a set. Intuitively, the meaning computed in ❶ can be understood as follows: there is a way of choosing books such that it's not the case that Juuna got the book so chosen. The basic move here is to quantify not over books directly, but over ways of picking out an individual book from the set of books. Every such way of choosing (i.e. choice function) corresponds to an individual book, namely the book that that way chooses. There are of course many such functions. One example way of choosing is a way where the book *Búsime nâpínek* is chosen. If Juuna did not get *Búsime nâpínek*, then the sentence is true. Let us call this way of choosing f_1, as in (37a). In formal terms, if Juuna did not get *Búsime nâpínek*, then f_1 witnesses the existential quantifier in ❶, i.e. makes the existential claim true. Similarly, if Juuna did not get *Aima qaa schhh!*, f_2 makes the sentence true. So on for f_3, etc. While it might seem that there is a quantification over books here that outscopes negation, what is really outscoping negation is the quantifier over *choice functions that apply to the set of books*.

(37) a. $f_1(\lambda x.books(x) \wedge |x| = 1) =$ *Búsime nâpínek*

b. $f_2(\lambda x.books(x) \wedge |x| = 1) =$ *Aima qaa schhh!*

c. $f_3(\lambda x.books(x) \wedge |x| = 1) =$ *Naasuliardarpi*

The truth conditions in ❶ are relatively weak. Ultimately, so long as there is any book that Juuna did not get, the sentence comes out as true. No one needs to have any such particular book in mind. Wharram (2003), following Kratzer (1998), proposes something slightly different: there is no existential quantifier over choice functions, and the sentence meaning is as in ❷. This meaning has a choice function variable that is left free. The value of the variable must be determined by context. Kratzer (1998) proposes to use this kind of meaning to represent a case where the speaker has a particular value for the choice function in mind. Given that a particular choice function over a set of books corresponds to a particular book, this amounts to having a particular book in mind. On this analysis, whether the sentence is true or not depends on whether Juuna got the particular book the speaker is thinking of. On this analysis, it is not technically true that 'a book' has in one way or another *outscoped* negation. There is no quantification over books or even choice functions, and thus no scope. There is simply reference to a particular book, one which the speaker has in mind. This provides a different way of understanding the basic facts on the interpretation of absolutives which ultimately is not about scope at all. We return to this question of whether there is existential quantification over choice functions at the end of this section.

5.1.2 Movement vs. choice functions: empirical tests

We have now seen that choice functions provide an alternative way of understanding why a Kalaallisut absolutive object cannot scope under negation. This means that inversion is not necessary, in theoretical terms, to explain the "wide-scope" semantic behavior of Kalaallisut objects. Next, let us consider ways in which the predictions of the choice function analysis diverge from those of the only-by-movement analysis.

The first concerns scope islands. On the only-by-movement approach, an absolutive can take scope over an operator only when it is able to move above that operator. When movement is blocked, wide scope should be blocked, too. Thus we expect Kalaallisut absolutives to show scope island behavior, just like uncontroversially quantificational expressions in English do (e.g. universally quantified DPs). The choice functional theory does not make this prediction. On this theory, absolutives can remain in situ and receive either wide scope existential readings (if there is an existential quantifier over choice functions higher up) or referential readings (if there is no such quantifier). No movement is involved.

Two environments that test the scope island prediction are *if*-clauses and (non-hyperraising) complement clauses. *If*-clauses are expected to block movement of material inside them due to the adjunct island condition.[33] Consider sentence (38). If the absolutive object *politikeri* 'a politician' is always a quantifier subject to scope islands, we expect only the reading schematized in (39a), where the absolutive existential quantifier ($\exists$) takes scope under the conditional operator ($\rightarrow$). On this reading, if they invite any politican, I will be happy. We predict that the reading schematized in (39b) will be unavailable: there is a certain favored politician, and if they invite *that* politician, I will be happy. On this reading, the absolutive existential quantifier ($\exists$) takes scope over the conditional operator ($\rightarrow$).

(38) Politikeri qaaqqup-passuk nuannaa-ssu-unga.
politician.ABS invite-3PL>3SG.COND be.happy-FUT-1SG.IND
If they invite a politician, I'll be happy.

(39) a. $[\exists x[$ *politician(x)* $\wedge$ *they invite x* $]] \rightarrow$ *I am happy* $\rightarrow > \exists$
b. $\exists x[$ *politician(x)* $\wedge$ $[$ *they invite x* $\rightarrow$ *I am happy* $]]$ $\exists > \rightarrow$

The context in (40) tests this prediction. In this case, the speaker is only happy if their favored politician is invited. That some politician or other is invited does *not* make them happy. In this context, the sentence in (38) is accepted.

(40) **Context:** There is a citizen meeting tomorrow. I don't know who is invited. There is a certain politican that I like so I will only be happy if she comes. I don't care about the other politicians.

Such data indicate that absolutives do not obey scope islands in Kalaallisut. (Wharram 2003 makes the same point for conditional clauses in Inuktitut.) This provides a first empirical reason to favor the choice function theory over the only-by-movement approach.

Complement clauses provide a second reason. Finite complement clauses are scope islands.[34] We will now see that Kalaallisut allows for scope out of these clauses as well. To make this argument, we must be careful concerning complementation structures that could involve hyperraising. Example (41), for instance, is acceptable in a context where there is a specific Greenlander who

[33] Such clauses block scope-taking for universally quantified DPs in English, for instance. Example (i) suggests that the addressee has a quite low course grade. If they complete the entire set of extra credit tasks, they will pass, (i-a).

(i) If you complete every extra credit task, you will pass.
a. ✓ $[\forall x_{EC}$ you complete $x] \rightarrow [$ you pass $]$
b. ✗ $\forall x_{EC}[[$ you complete $x] \rightarrow [$ you pass $]]$

(By the standard pragmatics of conditionals, we would typically assume in conversation that if they do not do so, they will not pass. Hence the implication that their course grade is quite low.) Example (i) cannot mean that the addressee has a marginal course grade, one that will be moved into passing territory by the completion of a single extra credit task. There is no reading with *every* scoping over *if*: every individual EC task is such that, if you complete it, you pass, (i-b).

[34] This is generally assumed to be true for various languages, including English, where finite complement clauses are not islands for Ā movement overall. (See however Barker 2022 for a refinement of the generalization for English. Barker argues that it is really finite speech/attitude complements, not just finite complements as a class, that constrain the scope of universal quantifiers. In keeping with Barker's findings, we investigate speech complements here.) In Kalaallisut, however, finite complement clauses are generally barriers to Ā movement. The only known cross-clausal movement in Kalaallisut is hyperraising. The clause-boundedness of Ā-movement in Kalaallisut is discussed at length in Mikkelsen et al. (2026).

Naja hopes that I marry (but it is not her general hope that I marry some Greenlander or other). In this example, the matrix verb 'hope' is inflected as a transitive verb with a 3SG object. There are two possible parses: it could be that the object is the entire embedded clause *kalaaleq ui-liuk-kiga*, and the embedded absolutive does not hyperraise. Or, it could be that the embedded absolutive *kalaaleq* 'Greenlander' does hyperraise into the matrix (though to a post-verbal position). On this latter parse, the wide-scope reading of the existential could be derived without the existential having to scope out of a finite clause. It hyperraises into the matrix and takes scope there.

(41) a. Naja-p neriu-tsiga-a kalaaleq
Naja-ERG.SG hope-TVZ-3SG>3SG Greenlander.ABS
ui-liuk-kiga.
husband-start.to.use-1SG>3SG.PART
Naja hopes that I marry a Greenlander. (a particular one)

b. $\exists x_{Greenlander}$[Naja hopes (I marry x)]

To avoid this confound, we consider embedding structures wherein hyperraising cannot apply. One such structure is embedding under 'tell'. For this verb, the matrix object agreement is reserved for the reported addressee (the one to whom something is told); the object agreement cannot track an embedded argument, and an embedded argument cannot be positioned linearly inside the matrix clause.[35] We take these restrictions to indicate that hyperraising is not possible with this verb. In (42), the sentence is true in the context provided only on a reading wherein the embedded absolutive scopes over the matrix negation. The sentence is accepted in this context, indicating that this wide-scope reading is in fact available.

[35]The following examples show that object agreement on the verb 'tell' cannot track the embedded subject (whether it is positioned before or after the matrix verb):

(i) * Angajoqqaa-tit illit oqaluttuup-pakkit angerla-jaar-tutit.
parent-2SG>3PL.ABS 2SG.ABS tell-1SG>2SG.IND go.home-early-2SG.PART
Intended: I told your parents that you went home early.

(ii) * Angajoqqaa-tit oqaluttuup-pakkit illit angerla-jaar-tutit.
parent-2SG>3PL.ABS tell-1SG>2SG.IND 2SG.ABS go.home-early-2SG.PART
Intended: I told your parents that you went home early.

Example (i) shows that the typical morphosyntax of hyperraising is not possible here: the embedded subject cannot appear immediately before the matrix verb and agree with that verb like an object. Example (iii) further shows that the object agreement alone is not the problem: even when the matrix verb does not agree with it (and rather agrees with the reported addressee 'your parents'), the embedded subject may not appear before the matrix verb.

(iii) * Angajoqqaa-tit illit oqaluttuup-pakka angerla-jaar-tutit.
parent-2SG>3PL.ABS 2SG.ABS tell-1SG>3PL.IND go.home-early-2SG.PART
Intended: I told your parents that you went home early.

We conclude that the hyperraising structure is not possible with this verb. The embedded subject may not move into the matrix clause, thus ruling out the word orders in (i) and (iii) and the agreement pattern in (i) and (ii).

(42) Context: I am baby-sitting three brothers ages 10, 12, and 16. The parents are very concerned that the oldest boy gets up early and goes to work on time. They don't mind the other two boys sleeping in. In fact all three boys sleep in. I plan to tell the parents that the two younger boys slept in, but I decide to not tell the parents about the older boy sleeping in.

angajoqqaa-t	oqaluttuuti-ssa-nngi-lakka	[nukappiaraq	sinnartu-soq	].
parent-PL.ABS	tell-FUT-NEG-1SG>3PL.IND	[boy.ABS	sleep.in-3SG.PART	]

I am not going to tell the parents that a boy slept in.

a. $\exists x_{boy}[\neg$ I will tell the parents (x slept in)] (true in context)

b. $\neg$ I will tell the parents ($\exists x_{boy}$ [x slept in])] (false in context)

This again provides evidence that absolutives do not obey scope islands in Kalaallisut, bearing out a distinctive prediction of the choice-functional theory. These data replicate and strengthen the essential argument in favor of choice functions from Wharram (2003).[36] Considering similar data in Inuktitut, Wharram concludes that "the structural position of noun phrases in Inuktitut is irrelevant in determining their scopal properties." Our scope-islands data suggest this is also true in Kalaallisut.

A second area where the choice-functional analysis diverges from the only-by-movement approach concerns negative polarity items (NPIs). On the latter approach, objects obligatorily scope over negation; they obligatorily move above negation, and cannot be interpreted any lower than in their derived position. This leads us to expect that Kalaallisut will lack NPI objects, because such objects are exactly those that must be interpreted in the scope of negation. Moreover, if absolutives generally must raise to a position above negation, we expect that there will be no absolutive NPI subjects, either. These expectations are not met. Bittner (1994a) shows that NPIs can occur in absolutive position (or in ergative position, or both) with no problem.

(43) a.

atuagaq	ataaser=luunniit	tiki-sima-nngi-la-q
book	one=any	come-PFV-NEG-IND-3SG

No book has come. (Bittner 1994a: 142)

b.

[inuu-p	ataatsi-l=luunniit]	[tillittuq	ataaser=luunniit]	taku-nngi-la-a
[person-ERG	one-ERG=any]	[thief	one=any]	see-NEG-IND-3SG>3SG

Nobody saw any thief. (Bittner 1994a: 142)

To handle these data, Bittner (1994a: 143) proposes that the NPI object in (43b) is actually an adjunct, and that an adjunct is allowed to (semantically) reconstruct. What her theory does *not* do is link these mechanisms in any way to the fact that (43b) contains an NPI. For this reason, it opens up a serious avenue for overgeneration in her theory. If verbs can generally compose with their notional objects in a way that permits semantic reconstruction, there should be no general reason why non-NPI objects scope above negation in Kalaallisut.[37]

[36] We note that Wharram's findings for Inuktitut are partially contested in Yuan 2021. Much further work is needed to assess possible variation across the Inuit family relating to scopal behaviors of arguments and the extent to which disagreements like this reflect variation in the data itself. We take Wharram's results to show that some Inuktitut speakers' grammars are well-modeled on the choice function theory.

[37] It would not be sufficient to claim, for instance, that non-NPI absolutives are all positive polarity items (PPIs); they must scope over other operators, too, e.g. 'again'.

By contrast, on a theory that attributes the behavior of non-NPI objects to choice functions, the behavior of NPIs is unsurprising. Recall that on Wharram's (2003) proposal, in choice-functional nominals, the choice functional variable is introduced in D. Suppose that NPI morphology (the suffix =*luunniit*) also instantiates D, but of a non-choice-functional sort. NPIs are generally understood as true existential quantifiers of a special type (e.g. those that trigger domain widening, via activation of alternatives; Chierchia 2006). From this perspective, the NPI data shows us that true quantifiers can indeed scope under negation in Kalaallisut (whether via QR to a low position, or in-situ interpretation). Reconstruction plays no role in this story; all Kalaallisut nominals can be interpreted in positions in the sister of negation. The apparent quantificational force of a nominal can nevertheless be above negation *if* that nominal is choice-functional.

5.1.3 Completing the picture: non-widest scope, ergatives

We conclude this section with two outstanding questions concerning scope. First is the question of non-widest scope in multiclausal contexts. We saw above that choice functional theories differ in whether they invoke existential closure over choice functions at the clause edge (Matthewson 1999, Dawson 2020) or rather leave the choice-function variable free and contextually determined (Kratzer 1998, Wharram 2003). For Inuktitut, Wharram (2003) defends the latter type of approach because indefinites in that language not only *can* but in fact *must* scope out of conditional clauses. We note that matters are different in Kalaallisut. In this language, it appears that scope inside a conditional clause is fully possible.

(44) **Context:** You and John have an old bicycle that you want to give to one of your 8 grandchildren (5 boys and 3 girls). I will be happy if you give it to a girl. It doesn't matter which girl.

Nuannaari-ssu-ara [sikkili-mik niviarsiaraq tuni-ussiuk].
be.happy-FUT-1SG>3SG.IND [bicycle-INST girl.ABS give-2PL>3SG.COND]
I will be happy if you give the bicycle to a girl.
$[\exists x[$ *girl(x)* $\wedge$ *you give the bike to x* $]] \rightarrow$ *I am happy*

For this reason, we suggest that the version of the choice functional approach most appropriate for Kalaallisut is one where existential closure over choice functions is permitted only at clause edges. This means that Kalaallisut choice-functional DPs do not have to have *widest* scope on an absolute basis, but that they do need to outscope operators such as negation internal to their own clause.

A final consideration is the scopal behavior of ergatives. Bittner (1994a,b) reports that whether an indefinite has to outscope negation correlates with its case: absolutives always outscope negation (modulo NPIs), whereas ergatives need not. She reports that (45) is ambiguous, and that in fact the narrow scope reading of the subject is preferred (1994a: 105).

(45) Suli atuartu-p ataatsi-p Juuna oqaloqatigi-sima-nngi-laa.
still student-ERG one-ERG Juuna.ABS talk.with-PAST-NEG-3SG>3SG.IND

a. It is not the case that there is a student who has talked with Juuna yet.

b. There is one student who hasn't talked with Juuna yet.

(Bittner 1994b: 57)

In principle, a difference of this sort could provide support for a theory like Bittner's where it is the syntactic position of a nominal, rather than its DP layer, that determines its scope. That absolutives have to scope very high, while ergatives do not, is in line with a picture where absolutives obligatorily move higher than ergatives. (See however Wharram (2003) and Yuan (2021) for alternative approaches to data of this general form, for Kalaallisut and Inuktitut respectively.) However, we cannot replicate this reported difference in absolutive vs. ergative scopal behavior. For the third author and our additional consultant (like for the 15 Inuktitut speakers consulted by Wharram 2003 and the two Nunavik Inuktitut speakers consulted by Carrier and Compton 2024), ergatives and absolutives are alike in obligatorily outscoping clausemate negation. The speakers we consulted do *not* allow the narrow scope reading of the ergative in (45a). The same holds in (46): the ergative indefinite cannot have a narrow scope reading with respect to negation. (This example replicates an Inuktitut data point from Wharram (2003: 40).) More work is needed to understand why our data differs from Bittner's on this point (whether variation of some sort, or an error of some sort).

(46) Piniartu-p ataatsi-p Ulloriaq taku-sima-nngi-laa.
hunter-ERG one-ERG Ulloriaq.ABS see-PAST-NEG-3SG>3SG.IND.NEG
A hunter didn't see Ulloriaq.

a. Context: Ulloriaq has disappeared. All the hunters went looking for her, but they didn't find her.
Judgment: #

b. Context: While the hunters are preparing for departure, Ulloriaq runs across the snow. All the hunters, except one, see her run.
Judgment: ✓

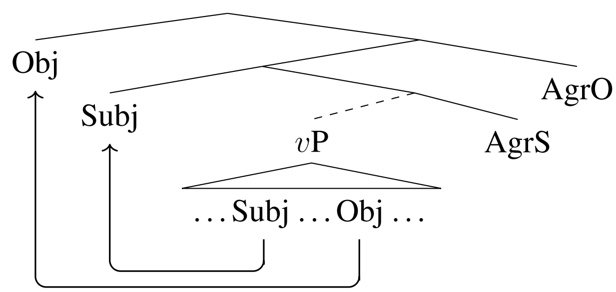
To summarize this section: the argument for inversion from scope rests on the premise that all Kalaallisut absolutives have the semantics of generalized quantifiers and take scope only by movement. Our data show that scope in Kalaallisut can be accomplished via an alternative mechanism (choice functions) that is not constrained by scope islands, connecting with modern work on 'exceptional wide scope' (Reinhart 1997, Winter 1997, Kratzer 1998, Matthewson 1999, Wharram 2003, Branigan and Wharram 2019, Dawson 2020, a.m.o.). Beyond the island data, the choice functional approach makes room for a simple account of NPI distribution in Kalaallisut, as well as a correct prediction concerning the scope of ergatives, at least for our consultants. We conclude (with Wharram 2003 on Inuktitut) that the scope of indefinites in Kalaallisut provides no evidence in favor of inversion.

5.2 Affix order: no support for inversion

Affix order in Kalaallisut and other Inuit varieties is put forward as an argument for inversion by Murasugi (1992: §3.1) (who cites unpublished work by Bittner), Bittner (1994a: 9), and Manga (1996: 96). The core observation is that, while transitive agreement in Inuit is sometimes an unparsable portmanteau, in some combinations, subject and object agreement can be separated out. The central empirical claim in this literature is that, when this happens, subject inflection is inside of object inflection. We will first present this argument in more depth and then respond to it in two ways. First, we will show that modern theories of ϕ-Agree dissociate the position of ϕ-heads in the clause and the positions of the arguments agreeing with those heads. Thus even if subject agreement were always inside of object agreement, no conclusion about object *movement* could be drawn. Second, we will suggest that subject agreement is *not* always inside of object agreement, linearly speaking; the empirical premise of the argument is not obviously true. We will suggest that the linear order of affixes shows a more complex distribution, one that is at least in part person-sensitive (Fortescue 1984, Oei 2005).

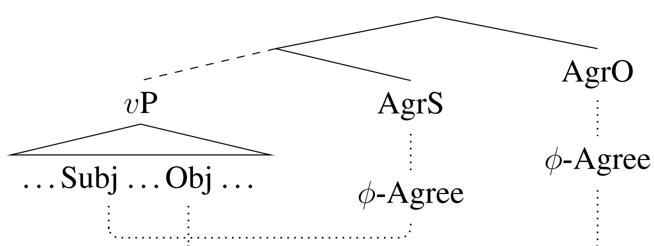
Consider, to begin, that a language might show agreement with both subjects and objects, with subject agreement linearly closer to the verb than object agreement: V-S.Agr-O.Agr. If we assume the mirror principle (Baker 1985), this suggests that the head responsible for subject agreement ("AgrS") is lower in the structure than the head responsible for object agreement ("AgrO"). Authors working in GB theory made, at this point, a crucial assumption: agreement requires a specifier-head relation. Therefore, the object must move to the specifier of a head above the subject. This means inversion. (In the tree in (47), we show the relevant specifier positions as on the left, though this is not crucial to this argument; neither, of course, are the particular labeling choices "AgrS" and "AgrO".)

(47)



This argument rests on the assumption that agreement is always spec-head, a view challenged in Chomsky (2001), Polinsky and Potsdam (2001), Bhatt (2005) and much following work. Contemporary theories of agreement require not a spec-head relation but rather a relation of c-command for agreement (operationalized via the operation Agree) to hold. Given a theory of agreement where Agree holds under c-command, it is perfectly possible to *accept* the mirror principle argument regarding agreement projections (as Yuan 2018, 2022 does, for instance) but to *reject* the further claim that the object moves above the subject. A structure where agreement does not lead to movement is schematized in (48).[38]

(48)



We conclude that, in light of modern theories of ϕ-Agree, affix order provides no evidence in favor of inversion, assuming the core empirical claim above is true.

[38]Questions of minimality arise in a structure like this regardless of whether nominals move to the agreement heads: how does the head that agrees with the lower argument enter into Agree with that argument, rather than the higher, closer nominal? On a pure Agree view (i.e. one where nominals do *not* move to agreement heads), two possibilities are that the AgrO ϕ-probe skips the subject due to activity (Yuan 2018) or else that that probe does Agree with the subject and then proceeds to also Agree with the object (Spreng 2006).

Is it true that subject agreement occurs inside of object agreement in Kalaallisut? The data are complex. Consider, to begin, the intransitive agreement paradigm for the indicative mood, (49). We see a nearly uniform *vu* across this paradigm; this morpheme might be analyzed as exponing indicative mood in the context of intransitive agreement.

(49) Intransitive agreement paradigm, indicative mood (Fortescue 1984: 288)

	SG	PL
1	-vu-nga	-vu-gut
2	-vu-tit	-vu-si
3	-vu-q	-ppu-t

When we turn to transitive clauses, as shown in (50), *vu* is replaced by *va*. The material following *va* in some cases but not others suggests a breakdown into two morphemes. We see the possibility of this type of analysis in a particularly clear way in 2A>1O forms such as *-va-ssinga* (2pl>1sg); this is plausibly *va-ssi-nga*, where *-ssi* and *-nga* resemble the corresponding 2pl and 1sg forms in (49). Similar remarks apply to 2pl/1pl form *-va-ssigut*. Overall, for the forms in the paradigm to the left of the double line, either (a) some amount of leveling has taken place, such that one argument's features are not exponed (this is so in the forms with 2pl objects, which trigger invariable *-va-ssi*), or (b) as noted by Fortescue (1984) and others, features of the subject are realized inside features of the object. Thus 1sg object forms all end in /a/; 2sg object forms all end in /it/; 1pl object forms all end in /igut/. This is a "column-based" (i.e. object-determined) pattern for the *final* segments in these forms. Importantly, these final segments are not only consistent, given a choice of object, but also in line with the shape of the corresponding intransitive morphemes in (49).

(50) Transitive agreement paradigms, indicative mood (Fortescue 1984: 289)

	1SG O	2SG O	1PL O	2PL O	3SG O	3PL O
1SG A	–	-va-kkit	–	-va-ssi	-va-ra	-va-kka
2SG A	-va-rma	–	-va-tsigut	–	-va-t	-va-tit
3SG A	-va-anga	-va-atit	-va-atigut	-va-ssi	-va-a	-va-i
1PL A	–	-va-tsigit	–	-va-ssi	-va-rput	-va-vut
2PL A	-va-ssinga	–	-va-ssigut	–	-va-rsi	-va-si
3PL A	-va-annga	-va-atsit	-va-atigut	-va-ssi	-va-at	-va-at

As noted by Fortescue (1984), the forms to the right of the double line are different.[39] These are the forms with third person objects. In this part of the table, the "column-based" pattern for final segments seen in the rest of the table disappears; the pattern of final segments is now generally row-based. Oei (2005), taking into consideration not just contemporary Kalaallisut but also an older version of the language (which included a dual form that has now been lost), along with five other Inuit varieties, argues that these forms in fact involve a reversal of the order seen in the rest of the paradigm: subject agreement occurs, here, *outside* of object agreement. In contemporary Kalaallisut, this is perhaps clearest in the 1pl and 2pl rows, where 1pl>3 ends in /ut/, similar to the 1pl form in (49), and 2pl>3 ends in /si/, similar to the 2pl form in (49).

[39] Fortescue (1984) observes that the material after *-va* in these cases is almost entirely identical to the forms used in possessive inflection, where the 3sg column above corresponds to inflection on a singular possessum and the 3pl column corresponds to inflection on a plural possessum. What if anything this similarity indicates in synchronic terms awaits further research.

What we take these close-up investigations of the transitive paradigm to show is that the relative order of subject and object agreement morphemes is not so simple a matter; nor is the mapping between syntax and morphology. By contrast to the person-sensitive pattern in agreement paradigms we have just seen—where 3rd person objects show a highly distinctive behavior—we are not aware of any corresponding pattern in the syntax (e.g. that third person objects move to a special position, or occur in a special form). A much closer study of the morphosyntax of Kalaallisut agreement is required to ascertain why agreement suffixes look as they do. For our purposes here, we have aimed simply to call attention to the fact that subject-inside-of-object order is not obviously systematically true throughout this entire agreement system—though as we have seen, even if it *were* true, it would still not provide a compelling argument in favor of syntactic inversion.

6 Theoretical and typological implications

We have now reviewed five types of data potentially bearing on the question of whether Kalaallisut clause structure involves obligatory inversion. Two of these (Condition C, hyperraising) have not previously been brought to bear on the question of inversion in this language; another (word order) has played only a minor role in previous work. As we have shown, the data from word order and Condition C are naturally accounted for on a non-inversion analysis, though as we noted they do not entirely rule out inversion. The data from hyperraising are more conclusive: they reveal that inversion is not obligatory, but that optional A-scrambling does exist. Turning to the types of facts previously considered evidence *for* inversion in Kalaallisut, namely scope and affix order, we have shown how neither body of data in fact presents a compelling case for inversion in light of modern theoretical frameworks and an expanded set of Kalaallisut data. We take this overall picture to strongly support a view of Kalaallisut clause structure that does not involve obligatory inversion.

In this section we discuss the broader consequences of these results, beginning with implications for the EEC. Having excluded inversion accounts, we review two types of analyses of the EEC that remain potentially viable. We then discuss the overall relationship between inversion and the EEC, building on Ershova's (2019, 2025) arguments that the two phenomena must be disentangled typologically and theoretically.

6.1 Implications for the EEC

If, as we have argued, Kalaallisut clause structure lacks obligatory inversion, then the EEC in this language cannot be accounted for in inversion-based terms. In this section, we sketch two alternative analyses for the EEC that do not involve inversion.[40] The first is based on case sensitivity: the relativization process is sensitive to case specifications. The second is based on antilocality: the distance between the transitive subject and the landing site of relativization must not be too short. While we leave the choice between these analyses to future work, in this brief discussion we aim both to demonstrate that EEC-sensitive languages lacking inversion can be captured with existing theoretical tools, and to lay some of the preliminary groundwork for further development and comparison of these views as applied to Kalaallisut.

[40]This is not an exhaustive survey of alternative approaches. Other analyses in the literature include, for instance, the PP ergative approach (Polinsky 2016); we set this view aside here as it makes the incorrect prediction that ergatives cannot participate in A-movement.

Our first non-inversion candidate analysis of the EEC is grounded in the idea that syntactic rules can be sensitive to case (the phenomenon of "case discrimination" or "case sensitivity"). Proposals to handle the EEC via sensitivity to case directly in Ā movement phenomena are made in Otsuka (2006, 2010), Legate (2008a), Deal (2016, 2017b) and Drummond (2023). We exemplify this family of analyses using Drummond's approach. Drummond argues that case sensitivity in Ā-movement arises from Agree: the probe that drives the movement can only move elements that contain both an Ā feature and a case feature (e.g. ABS). She implements this via conjunctive probing in an interaction/satisfaction theory. Following Scott (2025), a composite probe for [A] and [B] is one that is conjunctively satisfied by those two features, [SAT:A+B]. Formally, Drummond proposes that an absolutive-only relativization probe is specified [SAT:REL+ABS^{M}]; the ^{M} notation indicates a probe that triggers movement (Deal 2025b). A probe of this type can only move a relative operator when it finds the features [REL] and [ABS] on the same target. In a clause where an absolutive relative operator is present, it is found and fronted, producing a relative clause. By contrast, when no absolutive relative operator is present (e.g. because the [REL] feature is on an ergative argument), no relative clause can be formed. This delivers the EEC.[41] This probe behavior contrasts with an "ordinary" relativization probe, specified [SAT:REL^{M}]; this probe locates and moves the bearer of a [REL] feature, but is insensitive to case. A probe of this type is able to relativize ergatives, producing the non-EEC sensitive relativization patterns we see in some languages.

By connecting the EEC to a particular probe, the case-sensitivity approach naturally accounts for the fact that not all movement in Kalaallisut obeys the EEC. Hyperraising, for instance, moves the highest DP in the embedded clause; this probe does not reference case features and is fully able to access ergatives. Patterns of Ā-movement apart from relativization also do not show the EEC in Kalaallisut. As Mikkelsen et al. (2026) discuss, Kalaallisut has a focus construction which involves the focus marker *una* (a Cable 2010-style Q head, on their analysis) and obligatory fronting to the left periphery. Ergatives participate in focus movement just as non-ergatives do.[42]

(51) Uu-mam=una ikior-aanga
DEM-ERG=FOC help-3SG>1SG.PART
It was that one that helped me. (Mikkelsen et al. 2026: (32))

This type of variation internal to the Ā syntax of the language is handled on the case-sensitivity approach by appeal to the specifications of probes: the focus-fronting probe is sensitive strictly to [FOC] features, whereas relativization involves sensitivity both to [REL] and to [ABS].[43]

The case sensitivity approach foregrounds ergative case on the transitive subject and the case specifications of the relativization probe as the major factors underpinning the EEC. The structure of the relative clause matters only insofar as this structure contains the relativization probe. The

[41] More properly, it delivers a system where all non-absolutive relativization is ruled out; the pattern is not specific to ergatives. This claim is correct for the Kalaallisut relativization structure of interest here.

[42] Yuan (2022: 517) hypothesizes that the restriction of EEC effects to relativization in Inuit languages may simply reflect a general absence of A' movements other than relativization in these languages. The findings of Mikkelsen et al. (2026) show that this cannot be correct, at least for Kalaallisut: there *are* other A' movement dependencies in the language, but they do not show the EEC.

[43] This assumes that there is a feature [ABS] in Kalaallisut, that is, that all absolutives have a feature in common that relativization can be sensitive to. See Deal (2025a) for articulation of a case-sensitivity approach that does not require an [ABS] feature.

second non-inversion analysis we consider takes a different approach: the structure of the relative clause is key. In particular, on an antilocality approach, the EEC results when the transitive subject position is too close to the landing site of Ā-movement. The movement is thus "too short". An analysis of this type is developed by Erlewine (2016) for EEC patterns in Kaqchikel (Mayan).[44] Erlewine proposes that transitive subjects occupy Spec,TP, and that Ā movement targets Spec,CP. Movement from Spec,TP to Spec,CP is ruled out by the principle in (52).

(52) Spec-to-Spec Anti-Locality (Erlewine 2020: 2)
Movement of a phrase from the Specifier of XP must cross a maximal projection other than XP.

Erlewine proposes that intransitive subjects are not restricted in Ā movement because they need not occupy Spec,TP.[45] In general, on an antilocality approach, the fine details of which subjects may or may not be extracted in a language are expected to correlate with subject positions and the landing site of movement (Erlewine 2016, 2020, Liu 2025). Subjects that must be in relatively high positions are less likely to successfully extract. Movement that targets subject positions in relatively small clausal structures (or low specifiers in the clause periphery) is more likely to show subject extraction restrictions. To account for the fact that ergatives can be focus-fronted in Kalaallisut, for instance, we might appeal to the idea that the landing site of focus movement is structurally more distant from Spec,TP than the landing site of relativization is. Generalizing on this point, Liu (2025) notes that the antilocality approach makes it possible to articulate why the EEC should emerge in relative clauses specifically, in Kalaallisut and other languages, as opposed to other types of Ā dependencies: the structures where the EEC emerges are structurally reduced clauses, where the landing site of movement is too close to the Spec,TP subject position.

The possibility of a true explanation for the fact that the EEC is limited to relative clauses in Kalaallisut is one we find exciting. We note, however, that Kalaallisut does not, to our knowledge, offer any direct evidence that transitive subjects occupy a higher position in the clause structure than intransitive subjects do.[46] Some of the strongest evidence for antilocality effects crosslinguistically comes from cases where extraction is made possible by the addition of functional structure. In Kalaallisut, we might expect negation to provide a relevant test pattern. Compton 2018 argues that Neg intervenes between T and C in Inuit languages; Neg in this position is taken to obviate antilocality effects by Erlewine 2020. Negation is possible in participial relative clauses:

(53) Angut [$\_\__{\text{ABS}}$ angerla-jaa-nngi-soq] ikior-para.
man.ABS leave-early-NEG-3SG.PART help-1SG>3SG.IND
I helped the man who didn't leave early.

However, the addition of negation does not obviate the EEC in Kalaallisut.

[44] On antilocality as a constraint on movement generally, see Douglas (2017), Amaechi and Georgi (2019), Deal (2019), Issah and Smith (2020), Erlewine (2020), Newman (2020), Liu (2025).

[45] The idea that transitive subjects and intransitive subjects occupy different positions in the clause structure is further motivated by Massam (2009), Tollan (2018), Ershova (2025), Liu (2025), Burukina and Polinsky (2025).

[46] For instance, Tollan (2018) and Burukina and Polinsky (2025) propose that differences in subject positions can be diagnosed by the behavior of morphological causatives. They propose that intransitive subjects originate in / occupy Spec,vP, whereas transitive subjects originate in / occupy Spec,VoiceP. In a language where only intransitives can causativize, the causative morpheme can be understood to select only vP. This reasoning does not apply straightforwardly to Kalaallisut, however, given that both intransitive and transitive predicates can be morphologically causativized in this language (Fortescue 1984: 269).

(54) * Meeqqa-t [__ERG ikiu-nngik-kaannga] qiap-put.
child-PL.ABS help-NEG-3PL>1SG.PART cry-3PL.IND
Intended: 'The children who didn't help me are crying.'

This suggests that an antilocality approach for Kalaallisut would need to posit a position for transitive subjects higher than Spec,TP, e.g. a low specifier position in C domain.[47]

6.2 Typological implications

We agree with prior literature that *some* languages with the EEC have inversion. In our discussion of Condition C, for instance, we noted that Condition C feeding and bleeding provide evidence for inversion in Malagasy, Mandar, and Chuj; on the Keine and Bhatt (2025) theory of Condition C reconstruction, this is because objects in these languages are assigned case in a high, inverted position. Data showing similar types of Condition C behavior in another language should thus be taken, on our view, as a strong signal of case-motivated inversion in that language. And of course it is possible, in a language whose clause structure *does* have inversion, that inversion is relevant for Ā extraction. That is to say, we take our arguments in this paper to show not that inversion analyses of the EEC should be entirely discarded, but rather that they should be understood as limited in scope. The discovery of an EEC effect in a language is not sufficient to show that the language has inversion.

In considering the overall question of how the EEC and inversion are related typologically, we note that our findings provide a natural complement to those of Ershova (2019, 2025) for West Circassian. Ershova demonstrates that there is no EEC effect in West Circassian; ergatives participate in relativization in exactly the same way that absolutives do. Nevertheless, she finds several types of evidence for inversion. This of course is the exact opposite combination of properties that we find in Kalaallisut. Putting Ershova's arguments together with the main conclusions of this paper, we arrive at a picture on which the EEC and inversion are *entirely independent of each other*. We schematize the typology in Table (55), and, for simplicity, limit our examples to morphologically ergative languages.[48]

(55) Inversion and the EEC in morphologically ergative languages

	Obligatory inversion	No obligatory inversion
EEC	Chuj	**Kalaallisut**
No EEC	West Circassian	Hindi

We conclude with a look at how this typology can be understood through the two candidate analyses of the EEC in Kalaallisut presented in the last section.

On a case-sensitivity view, the dissociation between inversion and the EEC is expected. The EEC reflects the nature of probes in the Ā system; inversion reflects A-positions lower in the clause. Case-sensitivity in Ā probing works equally well to account for the EEC with and without inversion; regardless of whether the object is higher than the subject, a subject that lacks an [ABS] feature cannot participate in any Agree relation that requires such a feature. Similarly, inversion

[47] On the assumption that agreement is in the C domain in Inuit, see Compton (2018), Yuan (2018, 2021, 2022, 2026). This at least suggests that a head is present in this domain that engages with A-features.

[48] We note that outside of morphologically ergative languages, Drummond (2023) argues explicitly for a non-inversion approach to the EEC in Nukuoro (Polynesian Outlier).

does not entail that Ā probes case-discriminate, meaning that languages like West Circassian are also expected.

Matters are slightly more complicated on an antilocality approach. Starting with non-inversion languages, the difference between Kalaallisut-style and Hindi-style languages can be explained in terms of what positions transitive subjects move to and what positions are targeted by Ā movement, as discussed above. Only when the two positions in question are specifiers of adjacent heads in the functional sequence does the EEC result. For inversion languages, the situation is more complex. Inversion analyses typically take the object to move to the specifier of a functional head above the head whose specifier hosts the transitive subject. For Paul (2002), Brodkin and Royer (2024) and Ershova (2025), the object moves to Spec,TP. It immediately follows from this structure that the subject will not be constrained by antilocality in moving to the CP domain: movement from Spec,VoiceP to Spec,CP will cross Spec,TP, making it "long enough".

(56) Object inversion to Spec,TP
$[_{\text{TP}}\ \text{DP}_{\text{obj}}\ \ \text{T}\ \ [_{\text{VoiceP}}\ \ \text{DP}_{\text{subj}}\ \text{V}\ \_\_\ ]]$

A notable prediction of the antilocality approach comes from the fact that it is the object rather than the subject that occupies Spec,TP in (56): some languages with inversion should ban Ā movement of the object, rather than the subject. We are not aware of any known language that fits this profile, though we consider that the discovery of such a language could provide compelling evidence for antilocality.[49] In the known inversion/extraction data, the challenge for antilocality is the existence of languages like Malagasy, Mandar, and Chuj, where inversion co-exists with the EEC. By the logic just reviewed, antilocality is not sufficient to predict an EEC for a language with clause structure as in (56). It follows that, though antilocality may be a viable approach for explanation of EEC effects in some languages, it cannot be the correct analysis for *all* languages. This makes for a parallel with the inversion-based approaches with which we began this paper.

The history of linguistic analysis is littered with examples of phenomena that appear far less unified on close inspection than they do from far away. The study of ergativity in particular has seen numerous rounds in the dance of theoretical unification vs. disentanglement. In this paper we hope to have shown how the abandonment of a premature universal (viz., that all languages with the EEC have obligatory inversion) can go hand in hand with the deepening of our understanding both of how individual languages work and of how novel linguistic data can be connected to theory and typology.

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[49]In arguing that antilocality underlies that-trace effects, Erlewine (2020) points out that that effect is not specific to subjects in various languages; whatever occupies the specifier immediately subjacent to the movement-driving head will be constrained by antilocality. This is the same logic we use here.

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